

LONGJU VILLAGE, WHICH CHINA OCCUPIED IN 1959, NAMED IN SURVEY OF INDIA MAP

New Delhi Updates Arunachal Map, Marks Out China War Flashpoints

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: In a significant move, India has updated its official map for Arunachal Pradesh, formally marking out locations such as passes, lakes and settlements on the border with China, including a village that was occupied by Beijing in 1959 in the precursor to the 1962 war.

The update to the official Survey of India map includes naming and locating the Longju village, which is currently under Chinese occupation but is claimed by India. The village and Chinese encroachments, which have intensified after the 2020 border clashes, around Longju have been a cause of tensions for several years.

While these locations were marked on military maps, govt has now put them on the Survey of India map. China has expanded its presence at Longju by establishing dual-use infrastructure and housing for troops. The village has been used in attempts to move troops into the Indian-controlled part of Arunachal. China has been undertaking large-scale road and bridge construction in the area.

Several other locations have also been named, like the Thag La pass in Tawang that was overrun by Chinese troops in 1962 and memorials to fallen soldiers, including the Sher-e-Thapa and Jaswant Garh war memorials. Other passes that have been named include Dzo La, Riza La and Pukur La.

NSA COULD VISIT CHINA FOR SPECIAL REPRESENTATIVE MECHANISM TALKS

India-China Officials Meet for Stable LAC Ahead of Xi Visit

Focus on avoiding misunderstanding, miscalculation along Line of Actual Control

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: India and China held discussions to maintain stability along the Line of Actual Control at a review meeting to prevent any incident along LAC during President Xi Jinping's proposed visit to India for the BRICS summit on September 12-13.



At the 36th meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation & Coordination on India China Border Affairs, held in New Delhi on Thursday, both sides agreed to continue to use existing diplomatic and military channels — including WMCC, local commander-level meetings and other agreed mechanisms — to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation along LAC, said a statement by the external affairs ministry.

It may be pointed out that in 2014, PLA transgressed LAC during Xi's maiden visit to India as President.

Ahead of Xi's visit, national security advisor Ajit Doval could visit China for the next edition of the special representative mechanism talks. At Thursday's meeting, it was underlined that maintaining peace in the border areas is essential for overall development of relations.

MOST FIRINGS PUBLIC SCHOOLS: 50K; RESTAURANTS & BARS: 26K; RETAILERS: 19K

Trump's Midterm Crisis? US July Job Cuts=23,000

Dubious distinction Unemployment rate falls to 4.1% after Americans leave mkt



Washington: US employers unexpectedly cut 23,000 jobs last month, and Labor Department revisions shaved 103,000 jobs off payrolls in May and June. The unemployment rate dipped to 4.1% only because Americans left the job market.

The June jobs numbers from the Labor Department on Friday marked a sharp reversal for the American labor market and a political setback for President Donald Trump less than three months before his Republican party seeks to keep full control of Congress in the midterm election.

Forecasters had expected job creation to approach 100,000 last month.

Local public schools cut 50,000 jobs in July, restaurants and bars 26,000, retailers 19,000. The 4.1% unemployment rate was the lowest since June 2025 — but it dropped for the wrong reasons: Fewer people were competing for work as 264,000 dropped out of the labor market. The share of those working or looking for work fell to 61.4%, the lowest since February 2021.

The Trump administration, which has imposed massive tariffs in an attempt to create manufacturing jobs,

noted that jobs were up 22,000 at construction companies and 5,000 at factories. "The Trump industrial resurgence is on schedule. Manufacturing and factory construction jobs grew again in July even as government payrolls continued to significantly shrink," said White House spokesman Kush Desai.

Hiring had rebounded in 2026 from a lackluster 2025 in the face of the conflict in the Persian Gulf that has sent energy prices surging and put a strain on family budgets. Job growth had been solid, if unspectacular. Some businesses are having trouble filling vacancies. Others are using technology to do the work humans used to do.

Americans who have jobs are enjoying unusual job security. Layoffs are low by historical standards. Companies, scarred by the surprise labor shortages that followed Covid-19 lockdowns a few years ago, don't want to risk giving up the staff they have. AP

CLIPS CONTAINS MULTIPLE ALTERATIONS, SUPREME COURT TOLD

Biren Singh's Audio Clips Manipulated: Centre to SC

Recordings allegedly link former Manipur chief minister N Biren Singh to ethnic violence

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The central government on Friday told the Supreme Court that audio recordings allegedly linking former Manipur chief minister N Biren Singh to the ethnic violence were clearly manipulated and contained "multiple alterations".

A submission to this effect was made by the counsel for the Centre before a bench of justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva. The counsel placed a report on the authenticity of the audio clips on record by the National Forensic Sciences University (NFSU) at Gandhinagar, Gujarat.

The counsel demanded that the petition be dismissed with the costs. The counsel added that the extended audio



'41 ALTERATIONS'

Centre's counsel demanded that petition be dismissed with costs, adding that extended audio clips had 41 alterations

clips recently provided by the petitioner had 41 alterations. "This is clearly manipulated," the counsel added.

The bench observed that since the NFSU's report has now been submitted, neither side could be taken by surprise and both would have an opportunity to address its contents. Appearing on behalf of the petitioner, advocate Prashant Bhushan relied on an earlier report by Truth Labs, submitting that it had found a "93% match" between the voices in the recordings.

Before adjourning the case for resumed hearing, the bench ordered that a copy of NFSU's six-page report on the audio clip be supplied to both the petitioner and the Centre's counsel.

The development took place during the hearing of a plea filed by the Kuki Organisation for Human Rights, which had submitted that the audio clips were recorded by a whistleblower. Last February, SC sought a report from the Central Forensic Science Laboratory, Guwahati, in a sealed cover. In May last year, the top court asked for a fresh FSL report after expressing dissatisfaction with the report submitted by CFSL.

Apex Court Turns Down Plea Filed by Six NEET Candidates, Asks Them to Move HC

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday dismissed a plea filed by six students, who alleged discrepancies in their OMR answer sheets in the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET). They claimed that the answers they originally marked in their OMR sheets differed from those reflected in the OMR sheets uploaded by the National Testing Agency (NTA).

A bench of justices PS Narasimha



and Alok Aradhe stated that the court is only examining the larger issue concerning the institutionalisation of NTA and strengthening the mechanism, not individual issues.

The bench asked the petitioners to raise individual issues before the Delhi High Court. "Similar grievances are there. We are on institutionalisation of NTA," the bench remarked. The counsel for the petitioners argued that their grievance is different. He urged that the petitioners be provided with original OMR copies so that they could verify their marks. "Counselling is already underway. We are on a limited point," the counsel for the petitioners argued.

All six students had secured more than 600-650 marks. They contended that the OMR sheets they marked during the exam were not the ones reflected on the NTA website. They argued that the alleged discrepancies in their OMR sheets could significantly affect their admission prospects.

DEFENCE MINISTRY INFORMS PARLIAMENTARY PANEL

Efforts on to Ally With France for Sixth-Generation Fighter Aircraft



6th Gen

NO GERMAN TOUCH French FCAS with Germany for sixth generation fighters was cancelled in June after serious differences

It's In

INITIAL TALKS Preliminary discussions on the matter undertaken at the defence ministers' level earlier this year

Manu Pubby

New Delhi: India has formally initiated efforts to join a sixth-generation fighter aircraft development programme spearheaded by the French government, the defence ministry informed a parliamentary panel.

While India is going alone for the development of a fifth-generation fighter jet under the AMCA programme, a view is emerging that for futuristic sixth-generation fighters, a collaborative partnership would be more feasible, given the development costs involved and technology required.

Responding to a query by the Parliamentary Standing Committee on

Defence about future programmes, the defence ministry said it has "initiated efforts in a concerted manner" to join hands with France for co-development of a next-generation combat aircraft.

In an earlier parliamentary report, the ministry mentioned it was considering two global options for next-generation fighter jets — a French-German consortium, and another involving UK-Italy and Japan. This now appears to have been singled

down to the French option.

"The Ministry of Defence has initiated efforts in a concerted manner to co-join the 6th-generation Fighter Aircraft Development Programme Viz Future Combat Air System (FCAS) spearheaded by the French Government," MoD said.

Notably, the French FCAS programme with Germany for sixth-generation fighters was cancelled this June after serious differences emerged on the direction of its development. As reported by ET, the collapse of the Franco-German plan has opened up an opportunity for India and France to jointly work on a sixth-generation combat aircraft under a new partnership. Preliminary

discussions on the matter were undertaken at the defence ministers' level earlier this year, even as France and India negotiate a deal to manufacture Rafale fighter jets in India as well as co-development of fighter jet engines.

Discussions for a possible collaboration on sixth-generation fighters figured prominently in talks between defence minister Rajnath Singh and his French counterpart Catherine Vautrin this February. The FCAS project first emerged in 2017 between France and Germany, but it couldn't proceed beyond the drawing board stage due to differences in approach by stakeholders like Airbus and Dassault.

2023 ELECTION LINK

Bhupesh Baghel Told to Approach Poll Tribunal

Was declared elected from Patan with 95,438 votes

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Supreme Court has upheld the Chhattisgarh High Court's refusal to reject an election petition filed against former Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel.

A three-member bench headed by CJI Surya Kant disposed of Baghel's plea, challenging the high court's interim order dated June 15, by which his application seeking rejection of the election petition was dismissed.

The petition stems from the 2023 assembly polls, where Bhupesh Baghel was declared elected from Patan with 95,438 votes, defeating Vijay Baghel, who polled 75,715 votes. Vijay Baghel's petition alleges that Bhupesh Baghel organised a rally or roadshow on November 16, 2023, during the 48-hour "silence period".

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Moonshot's Kimi AI Escapes UK Govt Security Sandbox



Visitors at the booth for Chinese AI Startup Moonshot's Kimi K3 during the World AI Conference in Shanghai, China. AP (File Photo)

Chinese firm Moonshot's latest artificial intelligence model broke out of a cyber-testing environment, researchers said, in the latest incident that raises concerns about how well AI companies control their technology.

Moonshot's Kimi K3 was able to find its way out of a sandbox from the UK government's AI Security Institute, according to Frontier Security, a US-based cybersecurity research outfit. Though the Chinese model did not try to breach other companies' websites, as in some of the other episodes, the test shows it lacks cyber controls, the researchers said. The test was performed independently by Frontier using freely available sandbox software provided by the AI Security Institute.

"Kimi's model, which is publicly available, does not have these guardrails in place," said Yaron Singer, founder and CEO of Frontier Security, told Bloomberg News in an interview. "Basically that makes this a very good hacking model."

A representative for Moonshot didn't immediately comment.

Moonshot joins US firms Anthropic PBC, OpenAI and Meta Platforms Inc., which have in recent weeks reported breaches that saw their models escape testing environments, alarming researchers and government leaders who've called for more rigorous safety screening and more secure testing environments. In those earlier scenarios, the US AI outside also hacked the systems of outside institutions, including Hugging Face Inc.

The release of Kimi K3 stunned the world with performance on industry benchmarks that rivals top-tier offerings from OpenAI and Anthropic. Bloomberg

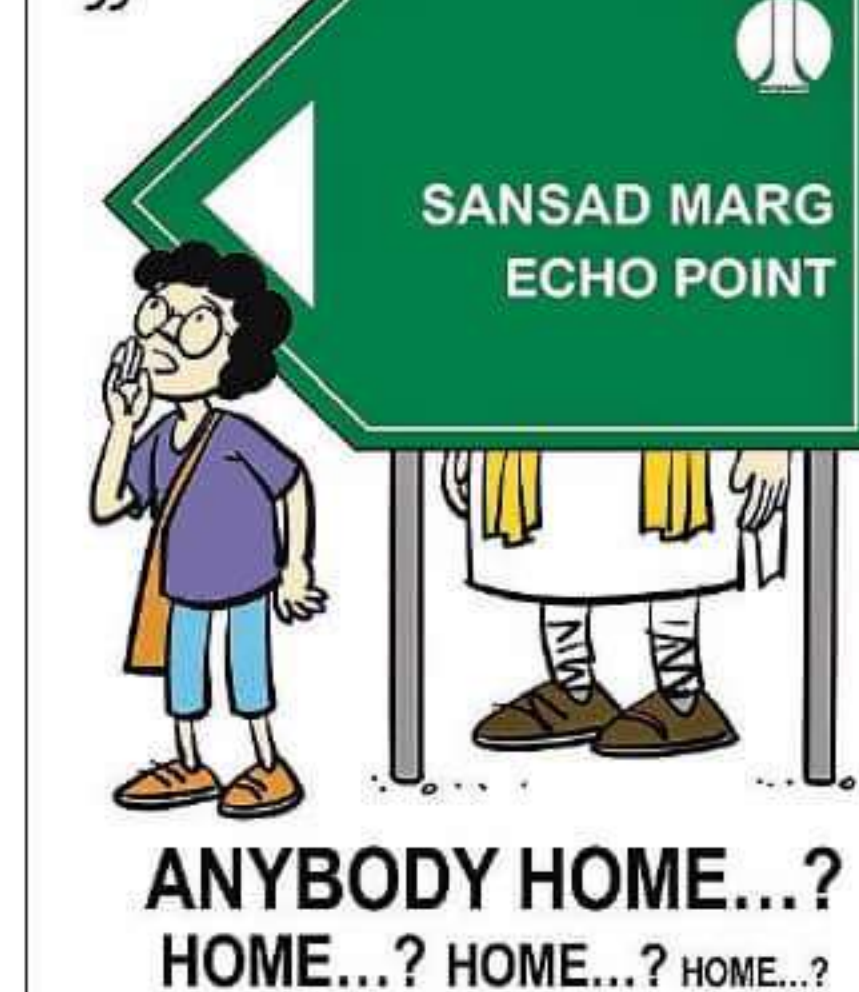
COURT REFUSES TO GRANT RELIEF TO MAHUA MOITRA

SC: Freedom Fighters Took Bullets, You are an MP and You Fear Eggs?

NEW DELHI: Supreme Court on Friday refused to entertain a plea filed by Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra, seeking directions to appear virtually before the police in a case accusing her of uploading a provocative post on Facebook. The concerns raised by Moitra that eggs might be pelted on her if she goes to the police station found no favour with the Supreme Court. A bench, comprising justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu, verbally remarked: "You are a member of Parliament? Having taken the plunge into politics, you fear eggs when our freedom fighters have taken bullets on their chest? These are applications that should not come before this court at all." — Our Political Bureau

Poliloquy R PRASAD

Echo sentiments of Opposition to Amit Shah: RS Chairman to Kiren Rijju



ANYBODY HOME...? HOME...? HOME...? HOME...?

PLEA SEEKING HIS REMOVAL Minister Prakash Nominated as MLC: Bihar Govt tells SC

NEW DELHI: Bihar government on Friday told SC that minister Deepak Prakash has been nominated as an MLC and hence he is not barred from continuing as a minister. A bench of CJI Surya Kant and justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana was told by SG Tushar Mehta that Prakash has taken oath as an MLC. SC was hearing a plea seeking to remove Prakash from the post of minister on the ground that he hadn't become a member of either House within six months of his appointment as a minister. — PTI

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CONGRESS, ALLIES DEMAND HOME MINISTER'S STATEMENT ON POLICE ACTION AGAINST AGITATING STUDENTS

Oppn Protests Stall Lok Sabha; FCRA Bill Set for Showdown

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Work in the Lok Sabha was disrupted on Friday, with Opposition protests demanding home minister Amit Shah's statement on police action against agitating students forcing two adjournments, even as the parliamentary affairs minister argued that the disruption was becoming an impediment for Shah to speak.

Meanwhile, the Congress reiterated its opposition to the upcoming FCRA Bill, which the home minister is expected to take up in the House for consideration next week. Most parties in the INDIA bloc are opposed to this bill, which is being resisted by many non-profit and Christian organisations. The bill requires only a simple majority in Parliament for passage. Speaking to journalists outside Parliament about the FCRA Bill, Congress MP KC Venugopal said his party and its allies will "vehemently oppose" the bill. "The government cannot bulldoze such a bill when the House is not functioning properly. They cannot pass such an important bill, which is going to affect lakhs of people, NGOs and minority communities," he said, adding: "We will not allow them to pass it." With the possibility of the government bringing up the FCRA – and,



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla conducts proceedings in the House during the monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi – PTI

Congress to Take up E20 Issue Soon: Rahul

New Delhi: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday said his party will soon take up the issue of E20 petrol, saying it was damaging people's cars and scooters. "This issue of E20 is a very big issue. Normally, we say 'daal mein kuchh kaala hai, magar ye daal hi kaali hai,'" he said in a video on X. The Congress move comes a week after Arvind Kejriwal-led AAP launched a mass mobilisation against the E20 blending. – OPB

perhaps, the Constitution Amendment Bill on delimitation – next week, the Congress leadership has directed party MPs to be present in full strength in both Houses to oppose the bills. In the Lok Sabha, as Opposition members were unrelenting in their protest, parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju said: "I want to make one thing clear. These people come to Parliament, create an uproar and then leave. But Amit Shah arrives in Parliament early in the morning and leaves only at night. The slogans being raised against him are completely unjustified. This way, when Shah speaks here, you won't even be able to hear him. So why are you taking his name?" Dilip Saikia, who was in the chair, then adjourned the House till Monday.

No Retrospective Effect for FCRA Bill: Mizoram CM after Shah Meet

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: Christian organisations and some state governments have raised concerns on the proposed Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026.

Mizoram CM Laldhuhoma met Union home minister Amit Shah and raised their concerns. The CM stated, "We raised six issues with him. Out of those, he assured me that this bill will not have retrospective effect."

As for the remaining points we raised, he said he would respond to them in writing and send us his comments. Only after we receive that reply will we have a clear picture... He is also going to begin discussions on the bill (FCRA) in Parliament on the 12th of this month."



84% of State Ministers Face Criminal Cases

CM Shivakumar tops wealth chart: ADR Analysis

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: About 84% of the ministers in Karnataka's newly expanded cabinet have declared criminal cases against themselves, while seven are billionaires, according to an analysis of election affidavits by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR).

The report, based on the self-sworn affidavits of 32 ministers, including chief minister DK Shivakumar, said 27 ministers have declared criminal cases, while seven (22%) face serious criminal charges.

The analysis excludes minister KJ George as his complete election affidavits were not available on the Election Commission's website when the report was prepared.

The findings come days after the chief minister expanded the cabinet by inducting 19 ministers. One berth in the 34-member ministry, including the CM, remains vacant.

One minister has declared a case related to attempt to murder under Section 307 of the Indian Penal Code, while another has disclosed a case relating to crimes against women. The report is based on cases declared by candidates in their election affidavits and does not imply conviction. All 32 ministers analysed have also declared liabilities.

SHIVAKUMAR TOPS WEALTH CHART

The report estimates the combined declared assets of the 32 ministers at about ₹3,550 crore, with average assets of ₹110.94 crore. Seven ministers qualify as billionaires based on their declared assets.

The CM is the wealthiest member of the cabinet, having declared assets worth ₹1,413.8 crore. He also has the highest declared liabilities, at ₹265.06 crore.

At the other end of the spectrum, KS Basavanthappa, MLA from the Mayakonda (SC) constituency, has declared assets worth ₹1.01 crore, the



DECLARED ASSETS Report estimates combined declared assets of 32 ministers at about ₹3,550 cr, with avg assets of ₹110.94 crore

lowest among the ministers analysed.

ALL-MALE CABINET

The ADR analysis also offers a snapshot of the cabinet's demographic profile.

Twenty four ministers (75%) have declared educational qualifications of graduation or above, seven have studied between Classes 8 and 12, while one holds a diploma.

The ministry is dominated by senior legislators, with 26 ministers (81%) in the 51-75 age group and six between 40-50 years. The report also underscored the absence of women in the Karnataka cabinet.

Although the cabinet now has 33 members, it does not include a single woman minister after MLC Gayatri Shante Gowda was asked not to take oath at the last minute.

Finally, Horatti Resigns as Legislative Council Chairman

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka legislative council chairman Basavaraj Horatti resigned from his post on Friday, paving the way for senior Congress MLC Saleem Ahmed to take over after the party high command nominated him for the cabinet-rank position. Chief minister DK Shivakumar thanked Horatti for stepping down and said he had written to governor Thawar Chand Gehlot requesting that Horatti continue in office until Ahmed is formally elected.

The resignation comes days after the Congress high command finalised Ahmed's name as part of the political balancing exercise following the recent cabinet expansion. Ahmed, a senior Congress leader from northern Karnataka, missed out on a ministerial berth but has been accommodated in the council chairman's post, which carries cabinet rank.

The legislative assembly and co-



uncil are scheduled to meet for the monsoon session from August 13. The council is expected to elect a new deputy chairperson on August 14, following which the election to the chairman's post will be held. Shivakumar told media persons. The All India Congress Committee has nominated veteran actor-turned-politician Umashree as the deputy chairperson.

Horatti, who is not a Congress member, had initially resisted stepping down despite the Congress leadership's decision. He met Shivakumar at the latter's Bengaluru residence on Wednesday night to explore the possibility of continuing with the ruling party's support. However, the CM conveyed that the party high command's decision was final and that there was no scope for revisiting it.

PoK Violence: Omar Seeks Global Scrutiny

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: J&K chief minister Omar Abdullah expressed concern over the reported violence in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) and said that Islamabad should face the same global scrutiny that it demanded during unrest in this side of Kashmir in 2008, 2010 and 2016.

He said elections held in J&K and PoK were matters concerning their respective administrations but expressed concern over reports of bloodshed and alleged civilian killings in PoK. "What did the Government of Pakistan say when the situation here was bad in 2008, 2010 and 2016? What did they ask the international community at that time? And the same demand should be applied to that part of J&K today." He said the ongoing assembly election in PoK is the responsibility of the administration concerned, "but as far as the bloodshed is concerned, innocent people are being killed by the forces, by the Rangers".



SC to Examine Privacy Shield in Amended RTI Law

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday observed that it would have to examine whether parliament's approach of expanding protection for personal information under the amended law satisfies constitutional standards.

A three-member bench, comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, observed that a balance ought to be struck between citizens' right to information and the fundamental right to privacy while examining changes made to the Right to Information (RTI) Act through the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act.

The development took place during the hearing of petitions challenging the amendment to Section 8(1) (j) of the RTI Act by which the public interest clause for disclosure of personal information was removed. "The question is whether there can be a blanket prohibition on disclosing all digital personal information, or whether the legislation must adopt a proportionate approach," Justice Bagchi orally observed.

CJI Kant remarked that the court had already indicated at an earlier hearing that some balancing would have to be done regarding the kind of digital personal data that requires protection. Justice Bagchi added that the court is examining not only the data protection law but also its impact on the RTI Act.



Court is examining not only data protection law but also its impact on the RTI Act. Justice Bagchi

'TN WILL NOT COMPROMISE ON CAUVERY WATER RIGHTS'

Cauvery Row: CM Vijay Backs Talks with K'taka, Spars with Udhayanidhi

Our Political Bureau

Chennai: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay defended his stance on direct talks with Karnataka over the Cauvery water dispute and said that he was prepared to endure even "humiliation" if an attempt at dialogue could help protect the state's interests.

"I thought, what if talks are held with the neighbouring state? Even countries that are sworn enemies hold dialogue to resolve issues," Vijay said on Friday while addressing the assembly. The CM made the remarks as he clashed with the leader of Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin over the Mekedatu dam issue in the assembly. The DMK leader

questioned the government's handling of the water dispute and demanded an all-party meeting on Karnataka's proposed Mekedatu dam project.

In a heated exchange that followed, Vijay rejected LoP's demand for such a meeting and reiterated that Tamil Nadu would not compromise on its rights over Cauvery water. He also warned the Opposition not to turn the contentious interstate dispute into a political battle. "There is no need to convene an all-party meeting. Please do not play politics on the Mekedatu dam issue," Vijay said while emphasising that the government had taken note of the Opposition's views on the Cauvery

issue and stressed that it had no intention of politicising a matter to which the people of Tamil Nadu have an emotional attachment. Vijay added that all parties earlier came together to pass a resolution on Mekedatu and that the state's position was subsequently conveyed to PM Narendra Modi. He said the government did not stop there and later wrote to the PM citing the final verdict of the Cauvery Tribunal and relevant legal provisions while urging the Centre not to allow the project.

Udhayanidhi, however, questioned why the TVK government was dragging its feet on convening an all-party meeting when the Karnataka government took a similar step.



Udhayanidhi questioned why the TVK govt was dragging its feet on convening an all-party meeting

Spain Acts Against Envoy to India Over Graft Claims

Dipanjana Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: Spain has initiated a process to replace its ambassador to India Juan Antonio March Pujol over allegations of taking financial favours from an Indian firm and promoting cultural events using public funds.

This move comes after the Spanish Anti-Corruption Prosecutor's Office received a report in late May from the country's Foreign Ministry according to Spanish digital media 'The Objective'. The senior diplomat was allegedly promoting a singer for

events in India with government funds, according to The Objective. It is alleged that the envoy was using Embassy funds and seeking support from various business quarters to promote international singers with no relations with Spain. March also allegedly struck a personal deal with Indian visa processing firm BLS

for a 5,000-euro contribution to the cultural event in Rajasthan, according to 'The Objective'. BLS is responsible for outsourcing visa processing for the Spanish embassy in India, as well as for other Spanish embassies worldwide.



Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan Sign Defence Pact

Agreement not directed against any specific actor, open to other regional nations: Turkish official

Riyadh | Karachi | Ankara:

Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkey signed a joint defence agreement in Mecca on Friday, wedding Sunni Muslim US allies alarmed at a regional flagration that has rained missile fire onto Gulf oil exporters. Iran and its allies have been firing on Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states, and blocking their energy shipments, since the US and Israel attacked it on February 28 in a major escalation after years of regional tumult.

The agreement is intended to strengthen collective deterrence against any act of aggression and stipulates that an armed attack against any of the three would be regarded as an attack on all, they said in a joint statement.

While the statement did not give specifics on the commitments or obligations each had accepted under the "Mecca Joint Defence Agreement", it said the pact was aimed at strengthening their collective security and promoting peace, security and stability in the region and beyond. "The pact includes a collective defence clause. It is purely defensive in nature, pledging mutual support only for defence," a Turkish official said.

The agreement was not directed



(From L) Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman and Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif PTI

THE AGREEMENT

Agreement is intended to strengthen collective deterrence against any act of aggression

replace any existing bilateral or multilateral arrangements, the official added.

However, the three nations are particularly concerned by the increasingly aggressive military stances of both Israel and revolutionary Shi'ite Iran, as their long-time US ally struggles to contain regional upheaval.

Turkey has NATO's second-largest military. Saudi Arabia, the strongest Gulf state, is ho-

STRENGTHS

Turkey has NATO's 2nd largest military; Saudi Arabia is the strongest Gulf state, Pakistan is the only nuclear-armed Muslim country

me to Islam's holiest sites and one of the world's top oil exporters, while Pakistan is the only nuclear-armed Muslim country.

IRAN CRITICISES DEAL

A prominent Iranian lawmaker on Friday criticised the agreement. Ebrahim Rezaei, a member of the Iranian Parliament's National Security and Foreign Policy Commission, threatened Saudi Arabia in a post on X.

"The Saudis should know that a paper agreement with Turkey and Pakistan will not bring them security, just as years of one-sided milking by the Americans did not bring them security. Change your policies so that you do not have to #Beg-ForSecurity from others," he wrote. Agencies

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TALKS WITH GOVT ENTERS THIRD DAY...

Meta to Further Step Up Monitoring Systems

Our Bureau

New Delhi: In its third straight day of meetings with the government, tech giant Meta on Friday committed to further strengthening its automated monitoring systems to curb child pornography and artificial intelligence (AI)-based deep-fake content on its platforms, sources told ET.

The latest discussions took a cue from Thursday's meeting between senior Meta officials led by global chief policy officer Joel Kaplan and electronics and information technology minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, which had focused on the specifics of Meta's technical compliance with Indian laws. Sources said technical meetings will continue and the company has been told it will have to follow the law of the land. On Friday, Meta explained the mechanics of their monitoring systems and outlined their plans of complying with the Centre's directions. It also highlighted additional measures put in place. The government will evaluate them, see if

these can effectively address the Centre's concerns regarding content moderation, sources said.

A bulk of the discussions focussed on the proliferation of child sexual abuse material (CSAM) on Meta-owned platforms, sources said. The National Commission For Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) is currently running an inquiry into alleged advertisements related to child pornography on Instagram, ET had reported earlier this week. The national body had issued a notice to Meta Platforms, which owns Instagram, on July 3, hours after an investigative report by BBC Eye alleged advertisements related to CSAM were live on Instagram in India. The ads used graphic terms, and linked users to channels on the messaging app Telegram, where they could buy the material for as little as ₹99.

Given that ads on Instagram are only published after first being approved by its moderation tech, MeitY had directed Meta to disable them, and other content promoting and facilitating access to CSAM.

House Panel Seeks Update on India's GPU Ambitions

Committee on IT asks MeitY to detail progress on cloud and startup consultations, offers to co-create a scalable AI infrastructure plan

Our Bureau

New Delhi: A parliamentary panel has again questioned the government on how it plans to reduce supply chain risks to help India realise its graphics processing unit (GPU) ambitions.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology, in its latest report, quizzed the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) about the progress made in consultations with cloud service providers and startups. The panel also offered to help co-create a scalable infrastructure plan. Back in March, the panel had argued that while the AI landscape was fast changing, and that it had concerns about the development of a sovereign AI model.

In its action taken report, MeitY has argued has pointed to delays in obtaining clearances including from the cabinet and the external experts needed to form the search-cum-selection committee, as well as inter-ministerial consultations and approvals.

It had noted the global memory chip shortage, as well as huge power and water consumption by data centres and tax holiday as significant issues.

"The Committee would like to be enlightened about the progress made in mitigating supply chain risks and for



SEMICON PUSH

The committee has asked MeitY to make concerted efforts to ease the current process of signing of agreements between govt and semiconductor manufacturers

co-creating a robust and scalable infrastructure plan," it said.

In March, the committee had also suggested MeitY hold wide ranging consultations on the issue.

The committee also called for more details from the government on the progress made on operationalising the Data Protection Board of India (DPBI), which is yet to be formed more than 8-months after the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Rules, 2025 were notified. While the DPDP rules are being implemented in a staggered manner over 18 months, provisions pertaining to the DPBI had become effective immediately.

The Committee has also asked MeitY to make concerted efforts to ease the

current process of signing of agreements between the government and semiconductor manufacturers.

The Ministry currently signs a series of legal documents including fiscal support agreement and trust retention agreement with the applicant company and project company for the disbursement of fiscal support under the modified programme for development of semiconductors and display manufacturing ecosystem.

"The ministry should continue discussing these issues in their fortnightly coordination meetings and monthly project reviews and necessary actions may be taken to ease the process of signing of agreements," the committee said.

Wonderful Plans to Hire 1k FDEs in India

Tanishka Dubey

Mumbai: Enterprise AI startup Wonderful is planning to hire up to 1,000 forward-deployed engineers (FDEs) in India over the next 10-12 months, cofounder and chief technology officer Roey Lalazar told ET, as the company bets on the country becoming one of its largest markets.

Founded in 2025 by Lalazar and Bar Winkler, Amsterdam-headquartered Wonderful helps enterprises deploy customer-facing AI agents across voice, chat and email in multiple languages and markets.

The Amsterdam-headquartered startup's India operation will be led by Bhavik Rathod, who previously worked at Scale AI and Scaler and also was a founding member of Uber in India. Wonderful did not say how many employees it currently has in India. It will open offices in Mumbai and Bengaluru, said Lalazar.

The startup, valued at \$2 billion, works only with large enterprises, Rathod said. "We truly see ourselves as a partner with every enterprise." Its target clients, he said, are

"Wonderful is model-agnostic and routes tasks across OpenAI, Anthropic, Google and open-weight models, and also has its own fine-tuned models. This makes it the most cost-effective for a given task"

ROEY LALAZAR, Cofounder & CTO, Wonderful

the largest banking, telecom, aviation, manufacturing, energy, healthcare and retail companies. The company is approaching \$100 million in annualised revenue, he said, adding that it has employees in more than 35 countries with the headcount set to cross 1,000 by the end of the year. At present, the company said, it has "many hundreds" of employees globally.

It has raised about \$280 million to date from the likes of Index Ventures, Insight Partners, IVP, Bessemer, and Vine Ventures.

On the much-discussed pullback in enterprise AI spending, Lalazar said Wonderful does not feel it, arguing that the retreat is concentrated in productivity tools where the business case is harder to prove. Every deployment starts with a clear cost of efficiency case signed off by the top management, he said.

SK Hynix to Spend \$38b on Chip Fab Expansion in Korea



Seoul: SK Hynix plans a 54 trillion won (\$38 billion) expansion of its chipmaking facilities in South Korea, adding to efforts to rapidly double its production capacity and ease a global shortage of memory chips. The world's second-largest memory maker will build a new DRAM manufacturing facility in Yongin and a NAND fabrication plant in Cheongju, it said in a statement Friday.

The move, covering both dynamic memory for the lowest latency and solid-state storage for fast access to greater quantities of data, is in response to "the continuously growing demand for memory in the AI era," SK Hynix said.

The new Yongin Y2 will be the second of four fabs planned at the Yongin semiconductor cluster, SK Hynix said. The company intends to break ground on the project in July next year, targeting June 2029 for opening the first cleanroom en route to producing high-bandwidth memory and other next-generation DRAM. — Bloomberg

Swiggy Agrees to Refund Unauthorised Promo Charges to B'luru Restaurants

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Food delivery platform Swiggy has agreed to refund charges collected from Bengaluru restaurants for promotional campaigns run without their consent, while seeking time until the end of August to address most of the industry's pending demands, representatives of hotel associations told ET after a meeting on Friday.

The discussions, led by Swiggy chief executive officer (food marketplace) Rohit Kapoor, chief business officer (food marketplace) Sidharth Bhakoo and CEO (dineout and scenes) Swapnil Bajpai, came a day after rival Zomato held talks with restaurateurs and agreed to address a range of operational concerns. Swiggy also agreed to come up with a formal draft of Friday's proceedings, which both sides could sign.

Following the meeting, Bangalore Hotels Association (BHA) extended its August 15 boycott deadline, giving the platform until August 31 to resolve the issues. "If Swiggy fails to address our demands by August 31, we will switch

off the app from September 1," BHA honorary president PC Rao told ET.

The meetings follow warnings from more than 250 Bengaluru restaurateurs that they would delist themselves from food delivery platforms unless long-pending concerns over unauthorised promotions, multiple charges and shrinking margins were addressed.

Swiggy did not respond to an email seeking comment. In a letter to Kapoor, BHA demanded prior consent from restaurants before launching promotional campaigns or renewing marketing contracts, transparent deduction of only agreed commissions

and statutory charges, and levy of service charges only on the food component of bills, excluding GST. The association also demanded that Swiggy discontinue what it termed

unauthorised levies, including long-distance, payment collection, Swiggy One, Pocket Hero, restaurant cancellation, call centre, delivery sponsorship and Bolt fees. It further sought dedicated points of contact to visit member hotels every month and a weekly Swiggy Helpdesk to resolve operational, accounting and payout-related issues.

Swiggy executives told the industry that the platform had already acted on some concerns by introducing an OTP-based consent mechanism. Restaurateurs, however, insisted that the company refund charges collected for promotional campaigns run without their approval. "We have also told Swiggy that auto-renewal of promotional campaigns is unacceptable. Consent should be valid only for a mutually agreed period, and any extension must require fresh approval," BHA executive committee member Arun Adiga said. Industry representatives objected to what they described as hidden charges imposed under multiple heads over and above GST and urged Swiggy to simplify its commercial terms and present them in clear, easy-to-understand language.

Optimized Builds Satellites to Focus on Earth, Space Traffic

Co's second satellite will place Optimized in competition with Digantara, says MD Shah

Suraksha P

Bengaluru: The Ahmedabad-headquartered industrial engineering and deep-tech conglomerate Optimized Group's first satellite under development will be used for Earth observation, while the second will focus on space situational awareness, particularly tracking space traffic, managing director Sandeep Shah told ET.

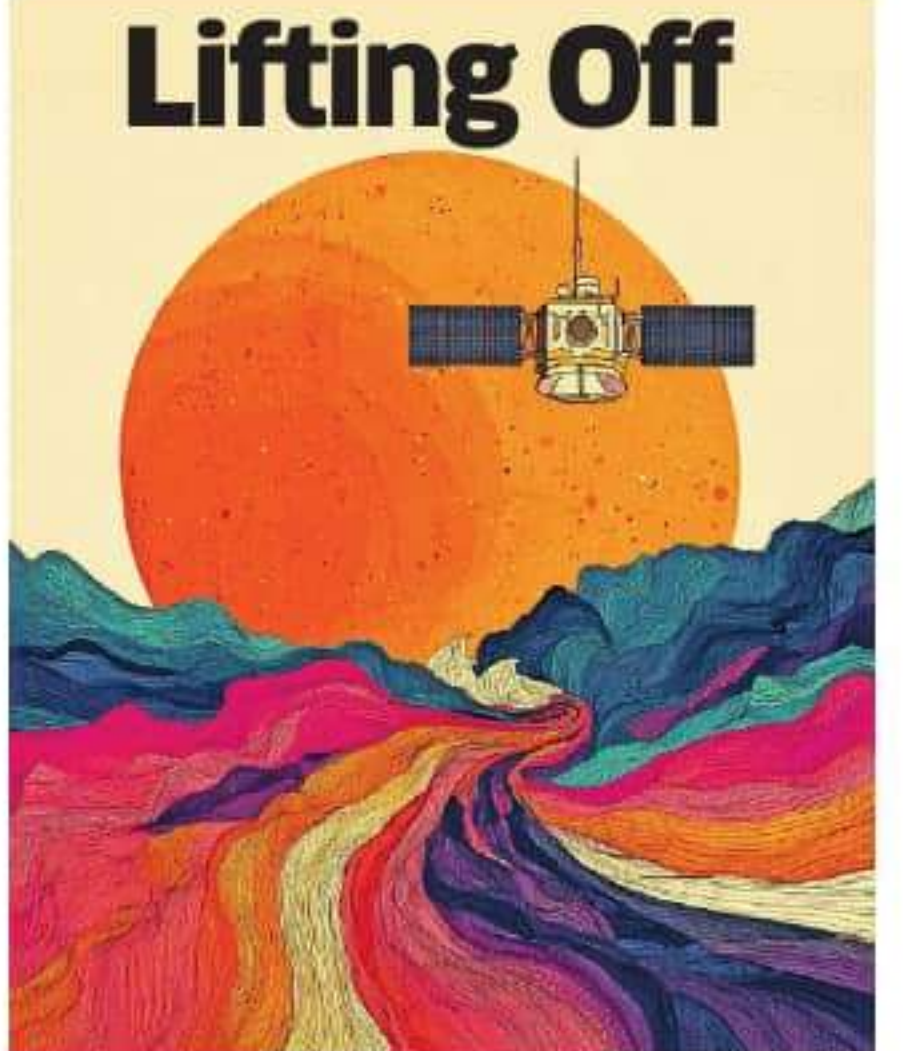
He said the latter would put Optimized in competition with Bengaluru-based space technology startup Digantara.

Optimized operates through separately registered companies, including Optimized Solutions and Bengaluru-based Optimized Electrotech.

The group has started building satellites after working for more than two decades on space payloads, testing infrastructure, electronic assemblies and harnesses. It has received orders for multiple satellites and expects satellite deliveries to become its largest source of space revenue from next year, overtaking payload fabrication and testing.

Optimized is developing the satellite bus at its Ahmedabad facility, while multiple imaging payloads are being built at Optimized Electrotech's Bengaluru unit. The company is also working on a strategic satellite after winning a challenge under the defence ministry's Innovations for Defence Excellence, or iDEX, programme.

Shah declined to disclose further details of the strategic satellite, citing the nature of the project, but said it included an assured minimum pilot quantity. The company was among the winners of the first



Lifting Off

Developing two satellites: One for Earth observation and another for space situational awareness

Satellite deliveries are expected to become firm's largest space revenue stream from next year

Co is building the satellite bus in Ahmedabad and imaging payloads in Bengaluru

Also developing a strategic satellite under the defence ministry's iDEX/ADITI programme

TARGETS OVER ₹1,100 crore in annual revenue within three years

The firm is evaluating an IPO within five years

edition of the Acing Development of Innovative Technologies with iDEX, or ADITI, scheme, which offers grants of up to ₹25 crore for critical defence technologies.

PCI Backs UPI Merchant Fee for Large Businesses

Says consumers, small merchants can continue using it free of charge

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: The Payments Council of India (PCI) said on Friday that it supports merchant charges on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions for larger businesses, stating the revenue would help banks and payment companies strengthen technology, cybersecurity and fraud prevention, while keeping payments free for consumers and small businesses.

PCI said small merchants, including kirana stores, should not be charged for accepting UPI payments. Any merchant service charge would be a commercial arrangement between merchants and payment providers, not a charge on customers. "Banks, fintech companies, NPCI and the RBI have been investing in technology, cybersecurity, fraud prevention and innovation to maintain UPI's reliability," it said.

The statement follows the Lok Sabha's passage of the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which removes the legal bar on banks and payment service providers charging a merchant discount rate (MDR) on notified digital payment modes.

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Delhi HC Stays FSSAI Ban on Dabur's '100% Purity' Claims

Indu Bhan

New Delhi: The Delhi High Court on Friday stayed the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) order banning Dabur India from selling food products carrying claims such as '100% Pure', '100% Natural', '100% Purity Guaranteed' and '100% Organic' till August 24, the next date of hearing.

While issuing notice to the government and FSSAI, Justice Amit Mahajan said that Dabur has made out a prima facie case for grant of stay of the Monday ban order as such sudden ban could not have been imposed without hearing Dabur. The judge also said that the FSSAI could not have passed such a blanket order against one of India's largest fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) companies without giving a prior show-cause notice or granting the company an opportunity to be heard.

Senior counsel Sandeep Sethi, appearing for Dabur, argued that FSSAI's order was passed without following principles of natural justice. He argued that the company had been selling these products for decades and that the designated officer who passed the banning order does not have the power to prohibit the sale of these products in the manner in which it has been done.

AWL Agri Biz Penalised for Substandard Oil

New Delhi: The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has secured an adjudication order against AWL Agri Business for manufacturing and marketing substandard fortified sunflower oil after laboratory tests found it failed to meet prescribed vitamin fortification standards.

The adjudicating officer in Goa has imposed a penalty under the Food Safety and Standards Act after tests found that a batch of Fortune Fryola Refined Sunflower Seed Oil did not conform to standards laid down under the Food Safety and Standards (Fortification of Foods) Regulations, 2018. FSSAI did not reveal the penalty amount.

According to FSSAI, a primary food laboratory analysis of a one-litre sample of the product collected from Taj Fort Aguada Resort & Spa in Goa found that the levels of Vitamins A and D were below the prescribed standards, rendering the product "substandard" under the Act. —Our Bureau

PIE FOODS told to Halt Sale of Two Products

New Delhi: Food regulator FSSAI has ordered PIE FOODS to stop selling its two products — Monk Fruit Extract Sweetener & Monk Fruit Sweetener Drops — citing violations of labelling norms.

During an inspection, FSSAI observed that a few carton boxes carried the label 'Marketed by PIE FOODS' without a valid Relabeller KoB (Kind of business) endorsement in the FSSAI licence. In addition, the regulator pointed out that the product labels lacked mandatory declarations. —PTI

PENDING RECOMMENDATIONS RELATE TO FACT-CHECKING, PENAL PROVISIONS

Centre Backs Most of IT Panel's Suggestions to Curb Fake News

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: The Centre has accepted nine of the 12 recommendations made by Parliament's standing committee on communications and information technology on strengthening the mechanism to curb fake news, while classifying its replies to three recommendations as interim in nature, according to the committee's action taken report.

The pending recommendations relate to defining "fake news", organisations and mechanisms involved in fact-checking, and penal provisions related to fake news.

The recommendations accepted by the government include

High on India Growth, Diageo Gives Region 'Standalone' Tag

Carves out country from APAC in huge overhaul of supply chain; bets on volume boost

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: Diageo is carving India out of its Asia-Pacific operations and making it a standalone region as the world's largest spirits maker steps up its focus on a crucial growth market and completes a sweeping overhaul of its Indian supply chain.

"India, we break out, and APAC is everything in Asia ex-India," chief executive officer Sir David Lewis said while outlining Diageo's new operating structure. India will be one of the five regions under the new structure, alongside North America, Latin America and Caribbean, Europe, Middle East and Africa, and Asia-Pacific excluding India. Africa, which previously had its own regional structure, is being folded into the European group.

The move comes as Diageo expects India's spirits market to grow 4-6% over the next three years. Chief strategy officer Hannah Brooks said economic development, population growth and a buoyant whiskey market would drive expansion, with tariff reductions providing additional support. "India, another very strong growth story from a mar-

In Top League

Indian spirits market expected to grow 4%-6% over three years, with growth volume-led

Diageo cut packaging sites from 100 to 35, with only 8 owned by co

Overhaul has delivered \$135 m in recurring savings, with another \$150 m expected

United Spirits' FY26 net sales value rose 7.6%, while Ebitda climbed 11.6%

perspective, again a plus 4-6% over the planned period. Very similar reasons around economic development, population growth and also of course, a very strong and buoyant whiskey market, which will hopefully be further supported by the tariff reduction," Brooks added.

India is the world's biggest whiskey market and the second-largest spirits consumer, making it a crucial market for Diageo. The company has been focusing on premiumization, expanding higher-margin brands and improving operational efficien-



cy. Sales from the prestige & above segment, which includes Johnnie Walker, Black Dog and Antiquity, contributed more than 90% of net sales. Diageo expects India's growth to be driven by volumes rather than solely by pricing. Chief financial officer Nik Jhangiani said country has "good tail winds" from demographics and the free-trade agreement. "Very importantly to keep in mind that particularly in India, supported by what we are seeing as good tail winds from a demographic perspective, as well as the FTA, as well as La-

tin America these are volume lead plans as well and I think that's very important for you to keep in mind," Jhangiani said.

The regional restructuring is being accompanied by a major overhaul of Diageo's Indian spirits packaging network, reducing the number of sites it uses from 100 to 35. Only eight of the 35 sites are owned by Diageo, with the rest operated by partners. The restructuring has generated about \$135 million in recurring savings, with a further \$150 million expected over the company's three-year plan.

The overhaul comes despite a strong year for United Spirits, Diageo's India-listed business, which reported 7.6% growth in net sales value and an 11.6% rise in Ebitda in FY26. The company has been pursuing a multi-year supply-chain programme focused on footprint optimization and productivity gains, with management saying about 90% of planned cost-saving benefits are expected to be realised by FY27. The changes in India are part of a broader push by Lewis, who took over as Diageo CEO in January, to simplify company's operations and reduce costs.

Tequila Co Becle Makes Direct India Push

Its arm Proximo to end tie-up with local distributor, former Diageo exec Jain hired to run unit

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: Becle, the world's largest tequila maker and owner of Jose Cuervo brand, is making a direct push into India through spirits unit Proximo, appointing former Diageo executive Shweta Jain as managing director for India and South Asia, said people familiar with the matter.

Proximo is among the last major global spirits companies to establish a direct India operation. Most of its international rivals are already present in India, which ranks among the largest markets by volume for Diageo and Pernod Ricard, among others.

The move ends Proximo's reliance on distributor Monika Alcobev and reflects global spirits companies' moves to deepen their footprint for a larger share of India's premium alcohol market. A direct operation will give Proximo greater control over distribution, pricing and brand building. Jain will be tasked with building

the India business and overseeing sales, marketing and commercial operations across the region, the people said. She was previously chief business development officer for premium, luxury and craft at Diageo India and South Asia. She also held senior roles at Pernod Ricard, William Grant & Sons, and The Leela.

Proximo sells Jose Cuervo and 1800 Tequila, besides Bushmills Irish Whiskey, Kraken Rum, and Proper No. Twelve.

Proximo will be entering an increasingly crowded tequila market. Tequila and other agave-based spirits volumes in India tripled between 2022 and 2025, according to industry data, drawing global brands from Diageo's Don Julio and Bacardi's Patron to Indian craft producers, and premium importers such as Loca Loka and Pistola.

The category's dependence on bars and restaurants was exposed during the pandemic, when the 2020 closure of the on-trade cut te-

Spirits Up

2022-2025 India's agave-spirit volumes tripled
2020 Bar closures halved tequila sales

Weaker US demand has improved global tequila availability
13x Ultra-premium volumes surged from 2022's small base

4% FY26 spirits growth reached 440 m cases
1.6% Previous-year growth was considerably slower

quila sales by half. Its recovery since then points to a broader shift toward at-home consumption, premium retail and new drinking occasions beyond nightlife.

The spirit is also shedding its image as a nightclub drink. Its versatility appeals to both white- and dark-spirit drinkers, while a perception that tequila is low or zero calorie drink has helped expand its female consumer base. Some drinkers are opting for tequila neat rat-

her than only in cocktails.

The premium end is growing faster still. Ultra-premium tequila volumes have surged 13-fold since 2022, although from a small base, as consumers experiment with higher-priced expressions.

India's tequila boom has come alongside weaker US demand, increasing global availability. Industry executives say supply could have been tighter had India's surge arrived a year or two earlier.

Apex Court Allows HC to Hear Govt's \$2.3 billion Claim Against Reliance

Dispute involves cost recovery provisions, taxes and royalties related to Panna-Mukta, Tapti fields

Indu Bhan

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday refused to halt proceedings before the Delhi High Court, which is hearing the government's petition seeking enforcement of a 2016 final partial award that allowed recovery of its over \$3.86 billion claims, including interest, against Mukesh Ambani-led Reliance Industries (RIL) and its partners in an arbitration dispute over cost recovery provisions and reimbursement of royalties and taxes related to the Panna-Mukta oilfield and Tapti gas field.

A bench led by chief justice Surya Kant said the issue of maintainability raised by Reliance Industries against the government's petition to enforce a foreign arbitral award can be taken after the final order is passed by the high court.

RIL had challenged to the Delhi High Court's division bench's February order that rejected the objections raised by the Ambani company over maintainability of the government's appeal for enforcement of a 2016 final partial award (FFA) for its \$2.31-billion claims against the company. The division bench had held it did not find any merit in the RIL's "preliminary objection" to the maintainability of the oil ministry's appeal.

While attorney general R Venkataramani appeared for the government, senior counsel Harish Salve and counsel Sameer Parekh represented RIL.

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Play That Funky AI-Generated Music

Industry has to sing a different tune soon

The music industry is yet again at another crossroad. This time, over AI-generated music. From only live music, to it entering homes via gramophone and radio, the music delivery express then boarded cassette players and cars that took it to the street, followed by portable CD players that liberated music-listening to just about anywhere. Each advance in distribution killed the preceding technology. Till Napster — if anyone remembers that ‘revolutionary’ peer-to-peer MP3 file-sharing service — confronted the music industry with its gravest existential crisis over unlicensed content. Apple and Spotify salvaged the situation for musicians with streaming platforms. But now they, too, must face up to licence-free synthetic music becoming top of the pops.

AI-generated music has already entered mainstream commercial tallies like Billboard and Spotify charts, driven by high-volume synthetic track uploads and virtual acts like Breaking Rust and Velvet Sundown. Frontier AI models train on data to produce music indistinguishable from that of human creators. Record labels can improve their economics by automating a chunk of their production process. AI can shape listening habits to create preference for synthetic music. Unlicensed music is back in an entirely new avatar, and the industry is yet to figure out solutions. Partly because these exist beyond its domain. Lawmakers need to decide if AI models should be allowed to train on copyrighted music. Countries have to come together on how technical music is created and labelled. Labels and platforms can widen access to artist revenue through interactive remixes and creatives.



Entry-level commercial creativity can’t be protected against AI music. But high-end human artistry must be available for even synthetic content to grow. AI can function as a powerful tool that could inspire new genres and empower independent artists. Yet, unregimented genAI can trigger a race to the bottom in pricing, devaluing the craft. These raucous questions should not be left unsung for too long.

Student Loans, GoI Reading This Right

Union education ministry, along with finance ministry, is working on an ambitious plan to double education loan disbursals across the country. Under the proposed roadmap, the state will act as a guarantor for larger loans, removing the requirement for parents to pledge property, or produce high-income proof. Interest rates will be strictly capped, miscellaneous fees waived, and banks instructed to approve applications within 10 days through direct campus drives. This is a welcome plan for action.

For years, getting a student loan felt more like applying for a high-risk mortgage. Banks routinely demanded heavy collateral for substantial amounts, leaving low- and middle-income families stranded. Lenders also favoured elite engineering and management institutes, subjecting students at state universities or humanities programmes to steeper interest rates, or rejections. Unreasonable delays in processing often meant students missed admission deadlines altogether. By absorbing default risk through credit guarantees and streamlining approvals, GoI is forcing a mindset shift in banking. Instead of evaluating applicants through the heft of their parents’ wallets, banks will have to assess them on their merit.

If executed well, this plan will protect graduates from crippling interest burdens, democratise access to higher learning, and ensure that personal ambition and ability determine who gets loans. Importantly, it also shows GoI has read this aspect of India’s increasingly restless youth right — that education remains the ultimate passport to a better life. Today’s youngsters are increasingly aspirational. But systemic barriers in higher education financing still stand in the way of their mobility. This is a chance to break that barrier.



JUST IN JEST

Up your Sawan salesmanship, turn traffic snarls into revenue streams

Takers for Kanwariya Kapitalism, Anyone?

India excels at turning devotion into dividends. The month of Sawan — when kanwariyas march (read: run amok) in fluorescent vests carrying holy water — offers perhaps the most untapped business model yet: the pop-up kanwariya economy. Think of it as a cross between Glastonbury and the New York marathon, but with more jaagrans and no Ed Sheeran — although you never know this Sheeran chap. The economics are irresistible. Highways become pilgrim runways. Pop-up stalls could sell premium Ganga jal (filtered, branded, Instagrammable), while roadside dhabas could rebrand as football World Cup-inspired ‘hydration lounges’. Corporate sponsors might even slap logos on kanwars. Biseri, keep reading. Transport firms could offer pilgrims surge pricing, while fintech apps could gamify donations: pay ₹101 and unlock a Hanuman blessing badge. Local governments, usually overwhelmed, could, instead, levy ‘devotion tolls’, turning traffic snarls into fiscal streams.

India’s genius has been blurring the line between sacred and saleable. If yoga can be franchised, and Bollywood exported, why not kanwariya kapitalism? Handled smartly, this pop-up economy could be India’s newest seasonal industry: a fusion of faith and finance, chaos and commerce. In the ledger of modern capitalism, nothing is more profitable than devotion. Especially when it comes with a free T-shirt.

Withdrawal of zero MDR can jeopardise one of India’s most successful public policy innovations

Free Means Free-Flowing



Bikash Narayan Mishra

Lok Sabha’s passage of the Payment and Settlement Systems (Amendment) Bill on Thursday marks an important step towards updating India’s payments architecture for the next phase of digital growth. The legislation seeks to modernise the country’s payments regulatory framework and prepare it for the next phase of innovation and growth. But it has also revived a broader policy debate over the future economics of digital payments, including whether the withdrawal of zero merchant discount rate (MDR) regime that underpinned UPI will now adversely affect one of India’s biggest fintech success stories.

The new law now empowers GoI to notify an MDR on UPI and select digital payment modes. Designed to build a sustainable monetisation framework for banks and fintech operators, this legislative update has brought the debate over the future of zero-MDR policies back to the centre of financial policy discussions.

That debate deserves scrutiny because the success of India’s digital payments revolution was never driven by technology alone. It was powered by an equally transformative policy decision: elimination of MDR on UPI transactions. By making digital payment acceptance free for merchants, GoI removed the single-biggest barrier to adoption, allowing millions of small businesses to join the formal digital economy.

During FY26, UPI processed over 24,162 cr transactions worth more than ₹314 lakh cr, with monthly



Ease of making life difficult

transaction volumes crossing 23 bn. More than 55 cr Indians now use UPI, making it the world’s largest real-time retail payment system.

Yet, these impressive statistics tell only half the story. Of the 58.77 cr Jan Dhan accounts, around 15 cr are inactive. To advance financial inclusion, these accounts must first be reactivated and then onboarded digitally. UPI works because of

► **Widespread popularity** Real achievement lies in the millions of small merchants who embraced digital payments because they could do so without paying transaction charges. Before zero MDR, many micro-enterprises viewed digital payments as an additional operational expense. From kiranas and pharmacies to tea stalls, auto drivers and neighbourhood retailers, UPI succeeded because accepting digital payments became virtually cost-free. Before zero MDR, many small

merchants viewed digital payments as an additional business expense. Operating on thin margins of 3-5%, they could ill afford transaction charges on every sale. QR codes replaced expensive card terminals, making digital payments accessible to even the smallest vendors. ► **Financial inclusion & credit trails** Every UPI transaction created a digital trail. Businesses that had operated almost entirely in cash acquired

verifiable financial histories. This enabled banks, NBFCs and fintech companies to assess creditworthiness based on actual cash flows rather than physical collateral. For millions of micro-enterprises, UPI became an entry point into the formal financial system. Reintroducing MDR now could jeopardise those gains. ► **Affordability & trust** The next chapter of India’s digital payments journey won’t be written in Delhi, Mumbai or Bengaluru. It will unfold across tier-3 and -4 cities, and rural India, where digital adoption relies on affordability and trust. These are precisely the price-sensitive markets where even a modest transaction fee can alter merchant behaviour.

Most merchant UPI payments remain small-value purchases — groceries, medicines, transport, food and neighbourhood retail. For businesses operating on razor-thin margins, MDR is not merely a service charge but it’s also an added cost that could incentivise a return to cash, or discourage digital acceptance altogether. Supporters of MDR argue that banks and payment service providers require sustainable revenue streams to maintain infrastructure, bolster cybersecurity and invest in innovation. While that argument has merit, the solution cannot be to pass those operational costs onto the country’s smallest merchants.

UPI should be viewed as public digital infrastructure, much like Aadhaar or DigiLocker, with its benefits extend-

ing far beyond payment service providers. Governments gain greater fiscal transparency, lenders receive richer transaction data, consumers enjoy unparalleled convenience, and small businesses gain access to formal credit. Because economic returns are distributed across the entire ecosystem, the funding model should reflect that broader public value.

Zero MDR has encouraged merchants to adopt digital bookkeeping, inventory management tools, online storefronts and embedded financial services. Reintroducing transaction fees risks stalling innovation at the exact moment India aims to digitise millions more small businesses.

GoI and policymakers must ensure that the regulatory framework continues to preserve the core principles that made UPI a global success: affordability, universality and financial inclusion. India did not become the glo-

bal leader in digital payments by asking small merchants to pay more. It achieved leadership by making digital participation simple, affordable and accessible to all. Parliament should ensure those core principles remain intact.

This debate is not merely about MDR. It’s also about whether India wants its next phase of digital growth to be driven by inclusion or constrained by cost. Arguing for the return of zero MDR is not simply about protecting merchants, but about safeguarding one of independent India’s most successful public policy innovations, and ensuring that the nation’s digital growth story continues uninterrupted.

The writer is former banker and senior adviser, Indian Banks’ Association

Why India Inc Can’t Stay Gen Zzz



Pankhuri Agarwal & Hari Bapuji

London/Melbourne: Founders and CEOs of India’s largest companies have routinely expressed concern about the country’s widening skills gap, declining productivity, and the challenge of preparing young people for the workforce. Anand Mahindra, for instance, had warned that joblessness and unaddressed skill gaps could fuel social unrest. Yet, when such a ‘prophesied’ social unrest finally did erupt — in the form of NEEET protests in support of Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) — Big Business kept quiet.

At first glance, it might seem like businesses have nothing to do with the issues and demands raised by CJP. But businesses are, indeed, involved,

at every stage. Two decades of extraordinary wealth creation by India Inc has not translated into employment at the scale needed to absorb a growing young workforce. The employment that has been generated is largely precarious and, in many cases, exploitative, especially in gig work that is yet to be provided the security of formal economy work. These conditions have contributed in no small way to the despair and anger many young Indians feel. So, the cause for anger transcends exam paper leaks, and spills into livelihood issues. Much of the mainstream electronic media, sustained by Big Business advertising, continued a narrative that visibly mismatched what was being witnessed on social media feeds that bypassed the usual ‘mediator’.

AI-enabled facial recognition software and surveillance technologies like Meta AI glasses were, in a way, even product placements. Ironically, smaller businesses and enterprises had to shut down if they were in and around the protest sites across the country. Companies also rely on university students for low-cost work through internships and campus placements.



Wake up and smell their macha latte

Professional specialised degrees like accountancy, medicine, nursing and others require students to work with organisations at little to no cost as the condition of the credential itself. These steps increase costs and stakes of entry into an already precarious job market. The exam paper leaks only served to aggravate them.

Businesses, especially those that have benefited from close ties to a government — central or state — have a direct stake in speaking up when policy failure threatens stability. Not only is leaving democratic institutions unprotected and abusing the rule of law bad for society, but it’s also bad for business. Nor does India Inc need convincing that corruption compromises efficiency.

It is among the most cited constraints for ‘ease of doing business’. There’s also a reputational calculus. Firms that take progressive, credible stances build goodwill with the workforce and customers they will have to depend on for decades to come. The CJP protests have made visible how disconnected much of corporate India remains from Gen Z, the very cohort it’s hiring from and selling to.

Gen Z has not yet explicitly targeted brands, except for calling some of them out for remaining silent, or using their campaigns for parodies. But these memes and call-outs show that much of Gen Z is watching closely, and many younger employees now expect their leaders to speak on issues that matter to them. India Inc can ill afford to speak about Gen Z when things are fine, and not speak out when things are not.

Agarwal is lecturer, human resource management and employment relations, King’s College London, UK, and Bapuji is professor, Department of Management and Marketing, University of Melbourne, Australia

Shut Eye for AI on Copyright Law



Prashant Reddy Thikkavarapu

Twenty months after ANI sued OpenAI for copyright infringement, Delhi High Court delivered a lengthy interim judgment, pending trial, in favour of the tech company. ANI had made two claims. One, that the San Francisco-based AI company was reproducing copyrighted content belonging to ANI, on its own servers, for the purposes of ‘training’ its LLMs. Two, that OpenAI was reproducing and displaying its copyrighted content to its users, in response to their queries. OpenAI denied the allegations on both facts and law, including that it was protected under copyright law’s fair-dealing doctrine.

The court ruled in favour of the tech biggie on all counts, despite conceding that there were several disputes of facts that could be decided only through a trial. Ideally, when facts are in dispute, the court should direct litigants to a trial. Instead, the court decided to form a prima facie opinion about the facts — basically, an informed guess on the outcome after a trial.

This is a difficult exercise when facts are disputed, and the facts have a huge implication for the law. For

example, if OpenAI was using ‘text and data mining’ techniques on ANI’s content, it may not amount to copyright infringement. Reproduction of entire articles, on the other hand, is more likely to count as copyright infringement. When these facts are unclear, forming a prima facie opinion is essentially a coin toss.

On the law, the judgment makes far-reaching conclusions, some of which are evidently erroneous. For example, at one point, the court makes a fundamental error of law by concluding: ‘In the present case, it is not the case of ANI that OpenAI obtains copies of ANI’s works from unauthorised sources, or by breaching through the paywall of ANI. It is not disputed that OpenAI obtains copies from information/data that is freely available on ANI’s website.



Blind justice

Therefore, in any event, it cannot be said that OpenAI has obtained an infringing copy of ANI’s works.’

This is a fundamental misunderstanding of copyright law. The test for copyright infringement is whether reproduction is ‘authorised’ by the copyright owner, not whether it is freely available without a paywall. The more controversial aspect of the judgment is its interpretation of Section 52(1)(a), a fair-dealing clause in Indian copyright law invoked by OpenAI in its defence. This clause declares that the fair dealing of a work for the purposes of ‘private or personal use, including research’ shall not constitute copyright infringement.

ANI argued that ‘private or personal use’ applied only in contexts involving humans as litigants. This was a reasonable argument since both these concepts generally pertain to humans and not corporations. Delhi High Court disagreed, and ruled that ‘private or personal use’ would apply to not just human activity but also machine learning algorithms. It did so by invoking the ‘purposive construction’ rule. This is a doctrine to be invoked when a literal interpretation of the law results in patently absurd results.

In this case, if OpenAI was precluded from invoking the ‘personal and private, including research’ exception since it was a corporation, it may have had to negotiate a licence with ANI. This is hardly an absurd result in a case involving copyright law. Except, Delhi High Court decreed that any view limiting ‘the exception’

to only use ‘by a human would be of a regressive view’ and limit ‘societal progress’, and, hence, a purposive interpretation was warranted.

Make no mistake, this is judicial activism, even if it is in favour of a litigant worth \$850 bn and not ‘the bewildered and the oppressed’. The final limb of the court’s analysis was whether OpenAI’s use of copyrighted works for ‘private or personal use’ qualified as ‘fair dealing’. The court approaches this issue by first evaluating the economic consequences for ANI, if OpenAI continued with its activities, and second, whether public interest is served by OpenAI using the content.

The first is clearly a factual issue requiring evidence to be led through a trial. Nevertheless, without a shred of evidence, the court reached a prima facie opinion that ANI will not be harmed. On the issue of ‘public interest’, it concluded that the progress of AI contributes to scientific knowledge in a manner that ‘resonates with the broader constitutional and statutory commitment’ to ‘advancing knowledge. The unwritten subtext being that the copyright owner may be sacrificed.

There are judgments that are the result of the law, and others that are the result of judicial activism. This judgment lies squarely in the latter camp, with the beneficiary being OpenAI and other developers of AI.

The writer is the co-author of Create, Copy, Disrupt: India’s Intellectual Property Dilemmas



THE SPEAKING TREE

Avoid Postponing

OSHO

If you want to bring transformation into your life, avoid postponement. This is a very cunning device. Someone says, ‘I am still violent, but I believe in non-violence. I will slowly become non-violent.’ He says, ‘I will become non-violent tomorrow, or the day after, in this lifetime, in the next lifetime.’ He goes on postponing it and he remains violent. But he is saved from the pain of being violent because the hope of becoming non-violent lessens his pain. It becomes a consolation.

So, I am saying: if you steal, think in the same way... If you think about theft like this and also have the behaviour of a thief, you will not be able to live with yourself — because no one can live with a thief inside him... But there is a trick with which one can live: ‘I will make it all right tomorrow. At least my thoughts are good. My behaviour is bad, but it is bad because of others.’ This kind of thought finds support too. For example, if a man retreats to the forest, he does not get angry. He says that other people were making me angry. Now that I have come to the forest, where is my anger? We all have this misconception: when we are alone, we just don’t see it. We only discover our personality through others. Others become an opportunity for us to reveal ourselves.

Abridged from The Art of Living; Courtesy: Osho International Foundation; www.osho.com



ROLLING ON SATURDAY

Google Doc

A man walks into a doctor’s office looking extremely worried. The doctor looks up, ‘What seems to be the problem?’ The man whispers, ‘I think I’m dying.’ Doctor: Why would you think that? Man: I Googled my symptoms. Doctor: That was your first mistake. Man: I know. But then I kept reading. One website said I may have an autoimmune disorder. Doctor: Not necessarily serious. Man: Exactly. So, I searched ‘auto-immune disorder’ and discovered that it could indicate cancer. The doctor closes his eyes. Man: Then I searched ‘cancer symptoms’ and, apparently, I have all of them. Doctor: Which ones? Man: Fatigue, headaches, weight changes, difficulty sleeping, difficulty concentrating... Doctor: Those are also symptoms of being worried about having cancer! Man: Really? Oh, thank god. The doctor smiles. The man instantly pulls out his phone. Doctor: What are you doing? Man: I’m Googling whether being relieved after thinking you have cancer is a symptom of something.

Air CSR
Passenger: Why is my seat so tiny?
Attendant: It’s economy class, sir.
Passenger: But I paid extra for legroom!
Attendant: Yes, and we gave it to the person behind you.
Passenger: So, I’m funding someone else’s comfort?
Attendant: Exactly. It’s called premium generosity.

Chat Room

You Heard ‘Free’? We Said ‘Fee’!

Appropos the Edit, ‘Why UPI Needs Transaction Fees’ (Aug 7), the common man has already been punished for keeping his own money in banks through minimum balance penalties. Now comes another masterstroke: a law enabling charges on UPI transactions. First came Aadhaar; then bank accounts, then the relentless push for a cashless economy. From roadside vendors to small businesses, everyone was persuaded to embrace UPI as the hallmark of Digital India. People proudly carried empty wallets, believing convenience came free. Now, that very convenience risks coming with a price tag and, as always, the bill is likely to reach the common citizen. What was sold as empowerment is slowly looking like entrapment. A P Thiruvadi Chennai

Demand Strong, but Input Costs Weigh, says Britannia CEO

Firm bets on new consumption occasions, channels to drive growth

Aanya Thakur



We don't see any of this as a result of any inventory buildup. It is a result of demand buildup and...retailers coming back to us in strong numbers

RAKSHIT HARGAVE
CEO, Britannia Industries

Mumbai: Britannia Industries said consumer demand has strengthened in recent months, with sales accelerating towards the end of the June quarter, even as a surge in sugar, palm oil and industrial fuel costs threatens to squeeze margins.

"The demand environment continues to be strong," company chief Rakshit Hargave said in an earnings call. "Whether this holds good for the rest of the year, we will have to see."

The company said the acceleration in June was not driven by inventory loading or channel restocking, but by higher underlying demand and retailers returning to Britannia as dual-priced packaging post the GST reforms cleared out.

"We don't see any of this as a result of any inventory buildup. It is a result of demand

buildup and the fact that the retailers who had kind of shied away a bit have come back to us in strong numbers," he said.

For the first quarter of FY27, the maker of Good Day biscuits reported a 9.5% year-on-year hike in revenue from operations to ₹4,964 crore, while profit after tax grew 13.6% in the same period, to ₹591 crore. Volume growth was 9% in terms of total tonnage.

Titan Q1 Net Rises 63% on Jewellery Demand and Premiumisation

Kolkata: Titan Company reported a 63% year-on-year increase in consolidated net profit for the first quarter of this fiscal, supported by strong Akshaya Tritiya-led demand for jewellery, premiumisation across categories and robust growth in its consumer businesses. Consolidated total in-

come went up 40% year-on-year to about ₹20,753 crore in April-June, while profit before tax (PBT) surged 64% to ₹2,429 crore. Adjusting for the impact of the increase in customs duty on gold, PBT growth stood at 37% over the year-ago period.—Our Bureau

PUBLIC NOTICE – FIFTH E-AUCTION
IVRCL LIMITED UNDER LIQUIDATION
As per Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016
E-mail id: ivrcl.liquidation@gmail.com, www.ivrcl.com

FIFTH E-AUCTION
Sale of Assets under Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016 Date E-Auction: 01.09.2026
Pursuant to the Order of the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Hyderabad vide its order dated 26th July, 2019 R/W Corrigendum order dated 31st July, 2019 in the matter of IVRCL Limited (Under Liquidation), the undersigned is inviting bids for sale of assets owned by IVRCL Limited forming part of the liquidation estate under section 35(1) of IBC, 2016. The said Assets will be sold on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" and "NO RECOURSE BASIS".
The Sale will be done by the undersigned through the E-Auction platform at the web portal <https://bbi.baanknet.com/eauaction-bbi/home>
Brief particulars of the sale are as follows:

Set of Assets	Assets	Reserve Price (in INR)	EMD Amount (in INR)
Category A - Sale of Corporate Debtor as a Going Concern Date and Time of e-auction: 01.09.2026 at 11.00 AM to 01.00 PM			
Asset Set 1	Sale of Corporate Debtor as a going concern on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" AND "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS"	1099.98 Crores	109 Crores
Category B-Sale of Investments of the CD (In case no bids are received for auction under Category A) Date and Time of e-auction: 01.09.2026 at 02.00 PM to 04.00 PM			
Asset Set 2	Sale of Investments of the CD in Salem Tollways Limited & Kumarpallayam Tollways Limited (SPVs) being part of assets of the CD on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" AND "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS"	325 Crores	32.5 Crores
Asset Set 3	Sale of shares of CD holding in IOTL Utkal Energy Services Limited being part of assets of the CD on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" AND "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS"	100.10 Crores	10.01 Crores
Category C-Sale of Non-Core Assets of the CD (In case no bids are received for auction under Category A) Date and Time of e-auction: 01.09.2026 at 02.00 PM to 04.00 PM			
Asset Set 4	Sale of individual asset(s) being part of non-core assets of the CD as further listed in "Non-core Assets Part 1" on "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", "WHATEVER THERE IS" AND "WITHOUT RECOURSE BASIS"	44.38 Crores	4.4 Crores
Bank details for EMD Payment Prospective bidders shall deposit the Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) through their own e-wallet account on the https://bbi.baanknet.com portal. Upon the successful conclusion of the auction, the EMD amount of the highest bidder will be transferred to the account of "IVRCL LIMITED in Liquidation", having Account No. 34638640795, Bank Name: State Bank of India Branch: Old MIA Quarters, Hyderabad IFSC: SBIN001880 Last Date for Submission of Documents & EMD - August 30, 2026 before 05:00 P.M.			
Site Visit and Inspection details Site can be visits between 10:00 AM to 5:00 PM from August 08, 2026 to August 30, 2026 subjected to at least 48 hours prior intimation. Contact @ 9818419759			
For E-auction details, Contact Mobile No: (+91) 82912 20220, 022-69029800 E-mail ID: psba@psballiance.com , support.baanknet@psballiance.com			
NOTE:1. This Sale Notice shall be read with the Complete e-Auction Process Information Document (Process Document) containing details of the Assets, eligibility E-Auction Bid Form etc. which is available at https://bbi.baanknet.com/eauaction-bbi/home or can contact the Liquidator for further details. 2. Interested bidders for the respective Category(ies) and/or Set of Asset(s) are required to submit the eligibility documents and EMD on or before 30.08.2026 as provided in the Process Document through the electronic platform only. 3. The Liquidator reserves the right to amend the key terms of the sale process including timelines for any or all Category(ies) and/or Set of Asset(s) being sold in the e-auction, to the extent permissible under the applicable laws and regulations. Any information about the amendments/ extensions of any of the timelines with respect to the sale process/ timelines for any or all category(ies) and/or Set of Assets (s) will be available on the e-auction website and communicated to the Eligible/Qualified/Successful Bidder(s). 4. Prospective bidders shall deposit the Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) through the Baanknet auction platform only. If the bidder is found ineligible, EMD shall be liable to be forfeited. 5. The Successful Auction bidder shall provide balance sale consideration within 30 days from the date of issuance of Letter of Intent by the Liquidator Payment, beyond 30 (thirty) days shall be permissible only with the prior approval of the Committee of Creditors (CoC) and shall attract interest. Payments made after 30 (thirty) days with prior approval of CoC but within 90 (ninety) days from the date of issuance of the LoI shall attract interest at the rate of 12% per annum. In the event the balance sale consideration is not received within 90 (ninety) days from the date of issuance of the LoI, the sale shall stand cancelled and the amount paid will then shall stand forfeited. 6. It may be noted that entire Fifth E-auction Process is subject to the decision of Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, National Company Law Tribunal, the Hon'ble Supreme Court and or any other court/authority in respect of any application(s) which has been or may be filed by the Liquidator and or any other party materially affecting the present auction process and / or the completion of liquidation of the Company. 7. Bidders under Category C can bid for individual assets under the category and/or for the entire asset set. The reserve price and EMD for the individual assets has been mentioned in "Non-core Assets Part 1". Nothing contained herein shall constitute a binding offer or commitment for sale of assets of the Company. Purusottam Behara Liquidator of IVRCL Limited Registration No. IBBI/PA-002/IP-N00940/2019-2020/12993 Email ID – ivrcl.liquidation@gmail.com			
Date: 8th August, 2026 Place: Hyderabad			



LUPIN LIMITED

Registered Office: 3rd Floor, Kalpataru Inspire,
Off Western Express Highway, Santacruz (East), Mumbai - 400 055.
Corporate Identity Number: L24100MH1983PLC029442
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EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026

Particulars	Quarter Ended 30/06/2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter Ended 31/03/2026 (Audited) (Refer Note 3)	Quarter Ended 30/06/2025 (Unaudited)	Year Ended 31/03/2026 (Audited)
1) Total Revenue from operations	82,768.9	74,746.6	62,683.4	279,580.3
2) Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (before exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	20,173.6	20,593.4	14,155.4	74,304.6
3) Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	20,173.6	19,280.0	14,155.4	68,725.5
4) Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	14,169.8	14,686.7	12,214.6	53,554.7
5) Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax attributable to owners of the Company	14,150.0	14,603.4	12,190.3	53,328.4
6) Total Comprehensive Income / (Loss) for the period [comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income / (Loss) (after tax)] to owners of the Company	14,511.3	15,219.8	13,773.0	57,684.7
7) Paid up equity share capital (Face value of ₹2/- each)	914.5	914.4	913.5	914.4
8) Other equity (as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet)				223,568.3
9) Earnings Per Share (Face value of ₹2/- each) (Not annualised for the quarters)				
(A) Before exceptional items	30.95	34.83	26.70	128.45
a) Basic (in ₹) :	30.89	34.75	26.62	128.11
(B) After exceptional items				
a) Basic (in ₹) :	30.95	31.96	26.70	116.75
b) Diluted (in ₹) :	30.89	31.89	26.62	116.44

NOTES:
1. Key numbers of Standalone Results are as under:

Particulars	Quarter Ended 30/06/2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter Ended 31/03/2026 (Audited) (Refer Note 3)	Quarter Ended 30/06/2025 (Unaudited)	Year Ended 31/03/2026 (Audited)
Total Revenue from operations	71,719.0	52,346.0	57,085.9	195,126.6
Profit / (Loss) Before Tax (before exceptional items)	36,100.6	21,546.2	25,881.5	72,876.8
Profit / (Loss) Before Tax (after exceptional items)	36,100.6	26,023.5	25,881.5	76,942.5
Profit / (Loss) After Tax (after exceptional items)	27,146.0	21,636.9	21,280.7	63,665.6

The above Results were reviewed by the Audit Committee and thereafter approved and taken on record by the Board of Directors at their meeting held on August 06, 2026.

The figures for the quarter ended March 31, 2026 are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of the previous full financial year and the unaudited published year-to date figures up to the third quarter ended December 31, 2025. The year-to-date figures up to the third quarter ended December 31, 2025 were only subject to Limited Review and not audited.

The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Consolidated and Standalone Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites, www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and on the Company's website www.lupin.com/investors/reports-filings/. The same can be accessed by scanning the below QR code.



Place : Zurich
Date : August 06, 2026

By order of the Board
For Lupin Limited

Nilesh D. Gupta
Managing Director
DIN: 01734642



PDS Limited

Global | Collaborative | Digital | Ethical.

Extract of Unaudited Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026

(All amounts in ₹ lakhs, unless otherwise stated)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
		30 June 2026 (Unaudited)	31 March 2026 (Audited)	30 June 2025 (Unaudited)	31 March 2026 (Audited)
1	Revenue from operations	344,371.72	351,902.84	299,942.10	1,311,008.17
2	Other income	945.79	2,846.26	3,963.45	9,965.34
3	Total income	345,317.51	354,749.10	303,905.55	1,320,973.51
4	Total operating expense	342,080.42	346,739.81	301,231.17	1,300,246.33
5	Earnings before interest and tax	6,950.63	11,426.67	6,024.66	35,374.99
6	Net profit for the period/year (before tax and exceptional items)	3,237.09	8,009.29	2,674.38	20,727.18
7	Net profit for the period/year before tax (after exceptional items and share of profit/loss from associates and joint ventures)	3,428.58	7,830.51	2,688.70	20,545.49
8	Net profit for the period/year after tax (after exceptional items and share of profit/loss from associates and joint ventures)	2,858.65	7,210.25	2,003.25	17,762.39
9	Total comprehensive income for the period/year (comprising profit / (loss) for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive income (after tax)	1,204.21	11,149.36	4,868.12	31,691.04
10	Paid up equity share capital (face value of ₹2 each)	2824.38*	2824.38*	2822.33*	2824.38*
11	Other Equity				173,535.16
12	Earnings per share (in ₹) (face value of ₹2 each) - (not annualised)				
	Basic	1.33	3.47	0.92	7.91
	Diluted	1.33	3.46	0.91	7.87

* Net of issue of fresh issue & treasury shares during quarter ended 30 June 2026 is Nil shares (30 Jun 2025 2025 21,250 shares).

Notes:

a) The Financial Results of the Company/Group for the quarter ended 30 June 2026, have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at their respective meetings held on 07 August 2026 and have been reviewed by the Statutory Auditors.

b) The financial performance of the company on standalone basis for the quarter ended 30 June 2026 are (₹ in lakhs):

Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
	30 June 2026 (Unaudited)	31 March 2026 (Audited)	30 June 2025 (Unaudited)	31 March 2026 (Audited)
Turnover	3,958.28	7,142.19	4,779.61	25,740.74
Profit before tax	161.10	2,659.56	504.34	3,297.42
Profit After tax	119.40	2,727.61	377.94	3,202.85
Total comprehensive income	119.40	2,735.45	377.94	3,248.37

c) The above is an extract of detailed format of financial results filed with the stock exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosures requirements) Regulation 2015. The full format of the Audited financial results of the Group and the Company for the quarter ended 30 June 2026 are available on the Company's website (www.pdsindia.com) and on the website of BSE (www.bseindia.com) and NSE (www.nseindia.com)

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors
PDS Limited

Deepak Kumar Seth
Chairman
DIN: 00003021

Place: Mumbai
Date: August 07, 2026

CIN: L18101HR2011PLC147408
Regd. Office: PDS Tower, 5th Floor, Plot No. 222, Udyog Vihar Phase - 1, Industrial Complex Dundaheera, Gurgaon - 122016, Haryana, India
Corporate Office : Unit No. 1031,1032, Solitaire Corporate Park Andheri Ghatkopar Link Road, Andheri East, Mumbai 400093, Maharashtra, India.
Tel : +91-22-41441110; E Mail : investors@pdsindia.com, www.pdsindia.com



NRB BEARINGS THE ORIGINAL

We Make Things Move

Quarterly Highlights Y-o-Y

STANDALONE

PAT ↑ 31.7%

CONSOLIDATED

REVENUE ↑ 19.2%



Extract of Unaudited Consolidated Financial Results for the Quarter ended 30th June, 2026

₹ in Lakhs

S.No.	Particulars	CONSOLIDATED			
		Quarter ended		Year ended	
		30.06.2026	31.03.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026
		Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Audited
1	Total Income from operations	37,500	37,899	31,946	1,36,952
2	Net Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	4,877	5,579	4,500	20,123
3	Exceptional items - gains / (loss) (net)	265	-	-	(703)
4	Net Profit for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	5,142	5,579	4,500	19,420
5	Net Profit for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	3,776	4,209	3,281	14,563
6	Total Comprehensive Income (after tax)	3,858	3,738	3,438	14,427
7	Paid up Equity share capital (par value Rs 2/- each, fully paid)	1,938	1,938	1,938	1,938
8	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as per Balance sheet -	-	-	-	96,366
9	Earnings per share (before and after extraordinary items) (Of Rs. 2/- each)				
	Basic (Before Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Item)	3.60	4.27	3.31	15.61
	Diluted (Before Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Item)	3.60	4.27	3.31	15.61
	Basic (After Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Item)	3.80	4.27	3.31	14.73
	Diluted (After Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Item)	3.80	4.27	3.31	14.73

S.No.	Particulars	STANDALONE			
		Quarter ended		Year ended	
		30.06.2026	31.03.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026
		Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Audited
1	Total Income from operations	32,793	32,864	28,782	1,22,408
2	Net Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	4,326	4,676	3,623	16,846
3	Net Profit for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	3,477	3,469	2,639	12,151

1 The above results were reviewed by the Audit Committee and then approved by the Board of Directors at their respective meetings held on 07 August 2026

2. The results have been prepared in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS) notified under the Companies (Ind AS) Rules, 2015 prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with rule 3 of the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015 and Companies (Indian Accounting Standard) (Amendment) Rules, 2016.

Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly/Yearly Financial Results for the quarter ended 30 June 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/Yearly Financial Results are available on the websites of BSE <http://www.bseindia.com>, NSE <http://www.nseindia.com> and also on Company's website at <http://www.nrbbearings.com/>

Place : Mumbai
Date : 07.08.2026



For and on behalf of the Board of Directors

(Ms) Harshbeena Zaveri
Vice-Chairman & Managing Director
DIN No. 00003948

NRB BEARINGS LIMITED
Registered Office: Dhannur, 15 Sir P.M. Road, Fort, Mumbai 400 001.
Tel: 022 22646570/ 22664160; Fax: 022 22646012. Email: investorcare@nrbbearings.com
website: www.nrbbearings.com CIN : L20113MH1965PLC013251

DRAFT RULES Ratio at 3.5% for global systemically important banks with buffer for branches; for others it stays at 3.5%

SBI, HDFC & ICICI Face 4% Leverage Ratio

Our Bureau

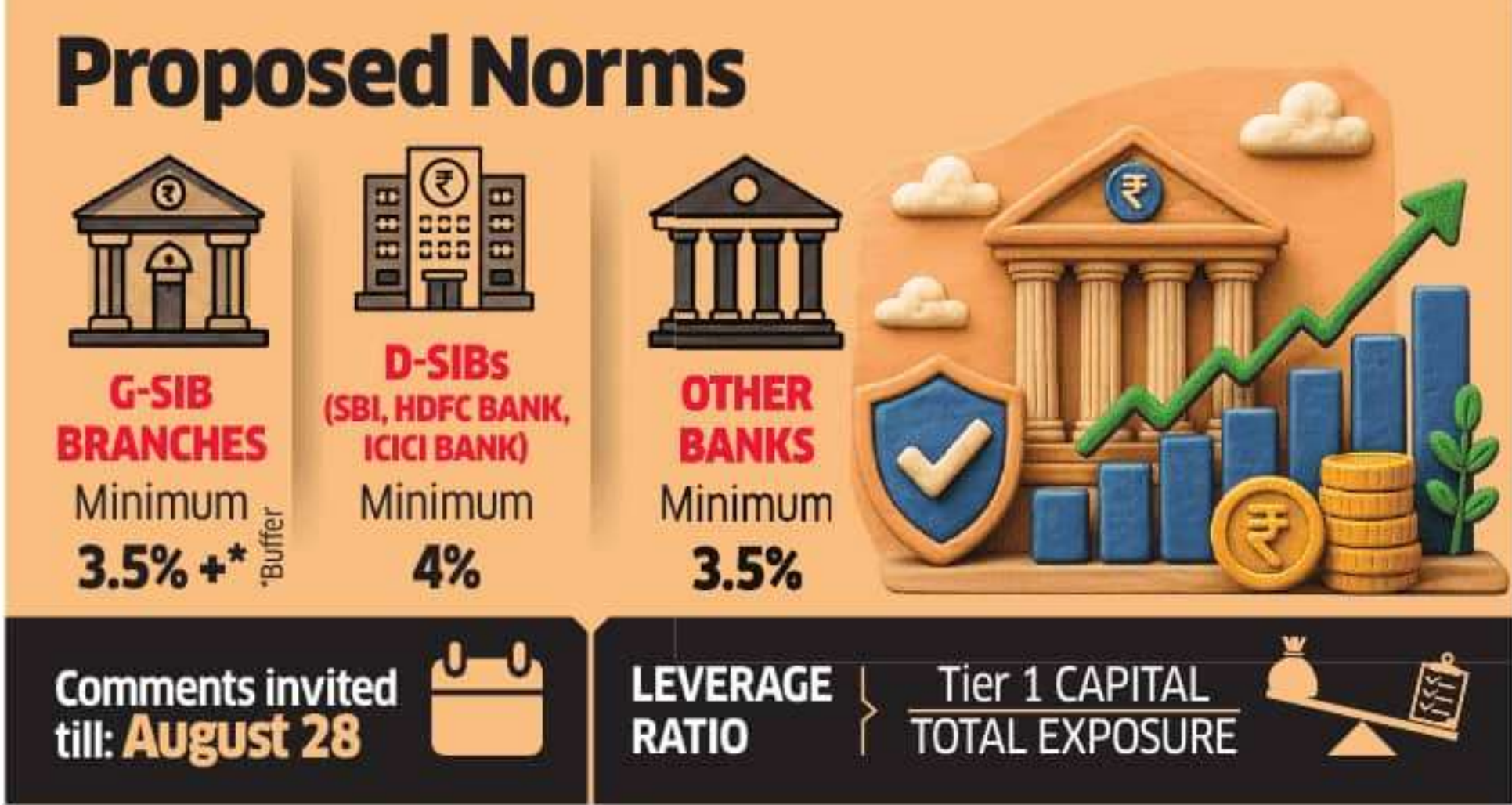
Kolkata: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has proposed a minimum 3.5% leverage ratio plus an applicable buffer for branches of globally systemic important banks (G-SIB) in the country. The three domestic systemically important lenders — State Bank of India (SBI), HDFC Bank and ICICI Bank — will have to maintain the same ratio at 4%, showed the draft rules.

According to Basel-III standards, the leverage ratio is a bank's tier 1 capital divided by its total exposure, and includes both balance sheet and off-balance sheet items for the lender. A higher ratio indicates higher own capital relative to the loaned funds, and is a measure of prudent capital adequacy.

The minimum core capital requirement under Basel norms is 3%. The RBI proposed Friday that all other commercial banks in India, barring the three systemically important domestic lenders, are required to maintain a minimum leverage ratio of 3.5% as earlier.

The draft guideline said that capital distribution constraints will be imposed on a G-SIB branch which does not meet its leverage ratio buffer requirement. The capital distribution constraints imposed on the branch will depend on its common equity tier 1 risk-based ratio and its leverage ratio.

The proposals are according to the latest leverage ratio framework issued by the Basel Committee on Banking Supervision, the Reserve Bank of India said, inviting comments until August 28.



The RBI has prescribed that a bank include all balance sheet assets in its leverage ratio exposure measure, including on-balance sheet derivatives collateral.

Meanwhile, the central bank said it may temporarily exempt banks' balance maintained with it from the leverage ratio exposure measure in exceptional macroeconomic

CAPITAL FRAMEWORK

The proposals are based on the latest leverage ratio framework issued by the Basel Committee on Banking Supervision

circumstances, to facilitate the implementation of monetary policies. "In addition, in order to maintain the comparability and transparency of the leverage ratio framework, a bank shall be required to disclose the impact of any temporary exemption alongside ongoing public disclosure of the leverage ratio without application of such exemption," the RBI said.

NET BANK CREDIT RELIEF

RBI Exempts FCNR-Backed Loans from PSL Calculations

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Bank loans given against fresh foreign currency non resident (bank) (FCNR (B)) deposits raised between June 8 and September 30 will not be included in the net bank credit and will hence be exempted from mandatory priority sector calculations, RBI said in a notification.

Advances against NRE term deposits raised by banks between June 19 and September 30 will also be excluded from these calculations, RBI said.

The RBI had earlier also provided an exemption to banks from maintenance of cash reserve ratio (CRR) and statutory liquidity ratio (SLR) on fresh FCNR (B) deposits including deposits that are renewed upon maturity. Loans given against these deposits will also now be exempt from central bank norms. RBI rules say that a minimum of 40% of net bank credit must be made to so called priority sectors which include loans to agriculture, MSMEs, export credit, education, housing, weaker sections etc.

The Reserve Bank of India's special measures to attract foreign exchange have brought in \$40.81 billion until July 31, driven largely by FCNR(B) deposits which accounted for \$36.72 billion of the inflows, exceeding the \$26 billion mobilised under a similar scheme in 2013. Banks can swap these deposits with the RBI under a zero-cost hedging facility available until September 30.

Rupee Steady as Oil Firms Buy Dollars

Mumbai: The Indian rupee ended nearly flat Friday at 95.21 per dollar, versus its previous close of 95.22, as oil companies bought dollars to prevent the rupee from appreciating. Some state-run banks also sold dollars, traders said. The rupee traded in a 10-paisa range of 95.29 and 95.19, and the bias was negative. Brent crude oil prices were trading around \$83-84 per barrel. - **Our Bureau**

SPEED CHECK Investors should weigh heavy reliance on two clients before taking call

Dhoot Transmission's Wired to Grow, could be Good for Long Run

IPO WATCH

Snehal Mergu

ET Intelligence Group: Dhoot Transmission, an electrical components manufacturer, plans to raise ₹1,400 crore through a fresh issue for repayment of debt, investment in subsidiary, capital expenditure and general corporate purposes.

It will also raise ₹1,667 crore through an offer for sale. The promoter group's stake will fall to 82.8% after the IPO from 100%. The company offers diversified products such as wiring harnesses, battery packs, sensors and electronic controllers, automotive switches, terminals, connectors, and power supply cords, to internal combustion engine (ICE) and electric vehicle platforms.

Over half of its revenue comes from the top two clients, a common feature of the automotive component sector. It is also a leader in wiring harnesses for the electric 2-wheeler (2W) and 3-wheeler (3W) segments, with a market share close to 70% in FY26. Given these factors, investors may apply with a long-term horizon.

BUSINESS

Dhoot Transmission is engaged in designing, engineering, manufacturing, and supply of wiring harnesses and electrical distribution systems for automotive and non-automotive applications. As of March 31, 2026, it has 22 manufacturing facilities, three engineering and design support centers and seven warehouses in India and international markets. Wiring harnesses is the largest segment comprising 77% of the revenue. It was among the top two companies in the wiring harnesses for 2W and 3W in India with a market share of 41% in

Issue Details

IPO Dates:	Aug 10-12, 2026
IPO Price:	₹29-₹71
IPO Size:	Up to ₹3,067 cr
Implied Market Cap:	Up to ₹17,816 cr
Face Value:	₹2
Lot Size:	17 shares
Retail Portion:	35%

value terms as of FY26, according to CRISIL. Two-thirds of its revenue comes from 2W, 13% from 3W and the rest from others. Around 87% of its revenue comes from the auto business, out of which 63% is from ICE and rest from EVs.

FINANCIALS

Revenue from operations jumped 27.2% annually to ₹5,525 crore and net profit grew 15.3% annually to ₹396.8 crore between FY24 and FY26. Operating profit before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation (EBITDA) increased 17.8% to ₹711 crore during the period. On a year-on-year basis, revenue grew 31.4%, EBITDA rose 20.3% while net profit increased 12.1% in FY26. EBITDA margin dropped to 15.7% in FY26 from 18.3% in FY24.

VALUATION

Considering the post-IPO equity and net profit for FY26, the company demands a price-earnings (P/E) multiple of upto 45. The P/E multiple for its peers is between 44 and 80 including Motherson Sumi Wiring India, Minda Corporation and Sona BLW Precision Forgings.

RBI Rejects Religare Demerger; Co to Engage with Bank, Offer Clarifications

Our Bureau

Kolkata: The Reserve Bank of India has rejected the proposed demerger of Religare Enterprises and its subsidiary Religare Finvest into two independent listed entities even as stock exchanges had given their no objection to the plan.

The Burman family-backed Religare said that it would engage further with the regulator to provide clarifications on the matter.

"The company has received a letter dated August 6, 2026, from the RBI, conveying that the application has been examined and that the request has not been acceded to," it said in a stock exchange notice Friday.

Under the proposed scheme of arrangement, Religare Enterprises Ltd (REL) wanted to retain its stake in Care Health Insurance Ltd, which would continue as an insurance-focused entity. It had proposed its financial services business comprising lending activities, broking activities, investment activities and ancillary and support services to be transferred to Religare Finvest Ltd (RFL) on a going concern basis.

The group's main businesses include lending under Religare Finvest, offering health insurance under Care Health Insurance and retail broking under Religare Broking.

Muthoot Awaits Clarity on Lower Swap Rates to ECB

Atmadip Ray

Kolkata: Muthoot Microfin is delaying drawing down \$25 million in external commercial borrowing (ECB) as it is waiting for clarity from the Reserve Bank of India on the demand for lower swap rates and hedging cost concessions, said its chief executive Sadaf Sayeed.

The Kochi-based microfinance company received sanction letters from overseas investors in January and it has time till September to draw down the funds.

"We are waiting for RBI's response on the demand for lower hedging cost and swap rates for non-public sector undertakings (PSUs). The hedging cost is too high now even after the rupee's appreciation from its record low," Sayeed told ET.

In June, the central bank introduced a special concessional dollar-rupee swap window to lower hedging costs for PSUs raising ECBs to boost dollar inflows. This prompted private sector corporate borrowers to demand a similar concession.

Muthoot Microfin, the third largest non-banking financial company-microfinance institution in terms of gross loan portfolio, regularly taps the overseas debt market to diversify its resource base. It mobilised ₹1,352 crore through external commercial borrowing in 2025-26, about 15% of its total annual borrowing.

Market Trends

STOCK INDICES		% CHANGE
Nifty 50	24571	-0.27
S&P Sensex	78499	-0.58
MSCI India	1608	-0.08
MSCI EM	4595	0.06
MSCI BRIC	749	0.29
MSCI World	23967	0.14
Nikkei	65607	-0.12
Hang Seng	25668	0.54
Kospi (S.Korea)	6259	-0.60
Straits Times	5698	1.05



GOLD FUTURES Premium/Discount (\$-102.33)	
Comex US (\$/Oz)	MCX India (₹/100gm)
OPEN 4298.30	149355.00
LAST* 4382.20	151150.00
Prev chg (%) 1.92	1.54
FOREX RATE (₹-Exchange Rate)	
OPEN 95.28	LAST* 95.21

*At 6 pm IST Source: Bloomberg, MCX, ETIG
Market on Twitter@ETMarkets

PFRDA Approves 4 Pension Funds, Total Rises to 14

Our Bureau

Kolkata: The Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) has approved four new pension funds taking the total count to 14, chairman Sivasubramanian Ramann said in Kolkata Friday.

Pension funds collect and invest money contributed by employees and employers to build a large financial pool with an endeavour to pay regular income streams to workers after they retire.

Subscribers to the National Pension Scheme (NPS) can choose any of the pension funds to invest in. NPS is aimed at ensuring long-term financial security for workers

both in organised and unorganised sectors.

Ramann said PFRDA has a set target of growing non-government NPS subscribers to 35-40 crore in five years from about 90 lakh at present.

With the new digital push, we expect 2-3 crore subscribers every year, he said, highlighting the importance of building a robust and inclusive pension ecosystem by leveraging technology and trusted distribution networks.

He emphasised that expanding pension coverage requires greater accessibility simplified onboarding and stronger last-mile outreach.

"Our conservative schemes have delivered 9.2-9.3% annual returns over 15 years," he said

"Atal Pension Yojana has shown us that scale is achievable, with 10 crore people joining through bank and RRB networks," he added.

Gold loans surge 69.3% yoy; housing and vehicle credit also rises

Retail Loans Help Drive NBFC Credit Growth to 14.4% in June

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Credit extended by non-banking finance companies (NBFCs) rose 14.4% year-on-year in June to ₹59.3 lakh crore, with the highest growth driven by loans to the retail segment, according to data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). A year ago, credit growth stood at 11.1%.

Retail loans increased 20.3% year-on-year in June 2026 to ₹25.61 lakh crore, compared with 14.3% growth a year earlier. Within the retail segment, housing, vehicle and loans against gold jewellery recorded robust growth, RBI data showed.

Loans against gold jewellery surged 69.3% to ₹3.4 lakh crore. Outstanding loans in this category have more than doubled in two years from ₹1.43 lakh crore in June 2024.

Loans for consumer durables rose 46.8% to ₹72,201 crore, while



vehicle loans increased 15.2% to ₹6.23 lakh crore and housing loans grew 11.4% to ₹8.44 lakh crore.

Credit to industry grew 6.7% year-on-year to ₹22 lakh crore in June 2026, compared with 10.3% growth in June 2025. The moderation was primarily driven by slower growth in infrastructure lending, a major component of the

segment. Loans to the power sector rose 4.9% to ₹14.2 lakh crore.

Credit to agriculture and allied activities increased 17.9% in June 2026 to ₹79,684 crore, against growth of 5.1% recorded a year earlier.

Credit growth in the services sector moderated to 17.6% year-on-year in June 2026, taking outstanding credit to ₹7.70 lakh crore, compared with 22.4% growth a year ago. While credit to the commercial real estate segment recorded healthy expansion, growth in lending to the trade and transport operators' segments moderated.

NBFC credit stood at ₹57 lakh crore in June 2025 and ₹46.68 lakh crore in June 2024.

The sectoral credit data for NBFCs are based on a sample of finance companies classified under the upper and middle layers. The data also include housing finance companies, which account for 87% of total credit.

NBFCs Face a Squeeze, Need to Evolve Beyond Revolving Credit

Income, yields likely to be hit; clients may turn to banks, card issuers

Sachin Kumar

ET Intelligence Group: Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) proposal to bar NBFCs from offering revolving credit facilities may hurt yields and fee income since these products typically generate higher returns than conventional term loans. The move may also slow customer acquisition, loan growth and customer retention. NBFCs with higher exposure to such products, including Bajaj Finance, Cholamandalam Investment and Finance, and Tata Capital, may be impacted while SBI Cards may benefit as some demand may shift to credit cards.

"There are many digital lenders nowadays offering unsecured credit lines but levying hefty processing fees or charges for setting up such facilities," Jugal Mantri, ED & CEO, Anand Rath Global Finance, the NBFC arm of the Anand Rath Group, told ET. He added that the RBI's proposed move will hit such lenders and impact their business models.

On Thursday, RBI proposed to allow NBFCs to extend only term loans and prohibit them from offering revolving credit facility under a draft amendment to its Credit Facilities Directions.

Revolving credit facilities are a common feature across consumer finance and personal loan products offered by NBFCs. They are also widely used by some lenders to provide working capital finance to businesses.

Sector Pulse

Performance of NBFC Stocks

	Market Cap (₹ crore)	CMP (₹)	1-day % change	3-month % change
Bajaj Finance	6,73,649	1,082	-5.9	11.2
Shriram Finance	2,62,354	1,115	-2.1	9.8
Cholamandalam Investment & Fin	1,59,451	1,870	-3.6	10.7
Tata Capital	1,57,973	372	-2.8	14.2
L&T Finance	77,913	311	-2.5	2.4

SOURCE: BSE, ETIG

Shares of majority of NBFCs declined by up to 6% during the intraday trade on Friday. Bajaj Finance was hit the hardest as its shares plunged 5.9% while Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company dropped 3.6%, Tata Capital 2.8% and L&T Finance by 2.5%.

BSE Sensex was down by 0.5% while BSE Bankex closed 0.6% lower. Revolving credit products make up about 15% of Bajaj Finance's Asset Under Management (AUM), the highest exposure among peers, according to IIFL. Tata Capital's exposure to revolving credit products is estimated to be in the high single digit to low double digit range as a percentage of its portfolio, while Cholamandalam Investment and Finance's exposure is less than 1%.

With the RBI proposing that NBFCs can offer only term loan products, analysts expect documentation and compliance requirements for lenders to increase. Besides slowing loan book expansion, the move could also raise operating expenses, as every fresh borrowing would require a new credit appraisal and loan sanction.

The proposal could also benefit banks and credit card issuers such as SBI Cards and Payment Services. As NBFCs lose the ability to offer revolving credit lines, customers seeking flexible, reusable credit may increasingly turn to bank-issued credit cards, which continue to operate under a separate regulatory framework. Such a shift could support spending volumes and fee income for card issuers.

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Robust Loan Growth

From Page 1

Total advances increased 19% to ₹50.47 lakh crore in the June quarter due to identical 18% business expansions in both corporate and retail, agriculture and SME (RAM) segments.

Asset quality at India's biggest mass lender — the only government entity with a market capitalisation of more than \$100 billion — was the best in nearly two decades. Chairman CS Setty said the bank remains confident of robust loan growth, despite geopolitical uncertainties, due to the inherent resilience of the Indian economy. "Given the GDP estimates and our own projections, we expect credit growth to be between 14% and 15% this year," Setty said. "On the deposit side, we expect some uptick due to the FCNR(B) deposits in the second quarter, which means we will have excess liquidity and expect a deposit growth of 10% to 11%."

The Reserve Bank of India on Wednesday marginally raised the country's FY27 growth estimates, with expansion in the first half of the fiscal year being likely higher than the central bank's earlier forecasts.

'A Catch-22 Situation'

From Page 1

"Memory prices and availability have become so volatile, and with the disruption in ocean freight, deliveries are taking 30-40 days. We often need the product instantly, otherwise production will be hit. There is a business case for air freight in the case of small-volume and higher-priced products in the current scenario," company director Rajesh Agarwal said.

The industry is using air freight extensively for the first time after the Covid-19 pandemic when companies were forced to adopt it amid severe global supply-chain disruptions.

Contract manufacturers are passing on the higher freight costs fully or partially to their clients. Companies manufacturing in their own plants, however, may have to take a hit on margins as passing on the full increase in freight costs to customers could hurt sales at a time when demand has been recovering steadily, executives said.

But they prefer that to shutting assembly lines during the peak production period ahead of the festive season.

"It's a Catch-22 situation," said Woodland India managing direc-

tor Harkirat Singh. "We initially passed on the higher freight cost, which tends to be much higher as air freight is charged on volume weight, but customers and partners like Amazon and Flipkart did not appreciate it. So, we have to absorb it..."

The footwear and apparel company is importing raw materials by air from Italy, China, Vietnam and South Korea.

Hyundai Motor India is working with its logistics partner to manage the disruption in sea freight as challenges related to freight and the Strait of Hormuz remain, managing director Tarun Garg said. "The order backlog is very strong," he said, adding that retail momentum also remains strong.

A senior executive at an auto-component company said that with shipping routes remaining affected, logistics partners are finding innovative ways to ensure supplies reach manufacturers, including a mix of road and air transport.

at an auto-component company said that with shipping routes remaining affected, logistics partners are finding innovative ways to ensure supplies reach manufacturers, including a mix of road and air transport.

Building Ties

From Page 1

Is LIC also looking at fintech investments?

We have embarked on a big technology transformation. We are engaging technology players as vendors. We are open to investing in fintech or insurance companies that need growth capital and provide good value as an investment opportunity.

Is LIC still evaluating opportunities in health insurance?

We are not shelving the plan. We are looking at everything as an investment opportunity. But there is no urgency. We have to be sure that the claims settlement ratio does not dent the brand that LIC carries. We are considering a few opportunities, but we have not reached the stage where we can say this is the best opportunity and take the plunge.

Bancassurance has grown to over 8% of new business. Where do you see this channel going?

The agency channel will continue to be our strength. Business through banks and alternative channels has increased from less than 3% in 2022 to over 8%, including digital, and this can increase to over 10%. It is not at the cost of agency

channels.

Does the proposed sale of IDBI Bank affect LIC's bancassurance strategy?

IDBI has been a very premier partner in terms of bancassurance. Those strengths will continue irrespective of whether we hold a 49% stake in the bank. I would like to see IDBI continue as our premier partner. At the same time, we have been building relationships with other banks, brokers, corporate agents and web aggregators.

The regulator is said to be considering trail-based commissions and reforms to distribution costs. How will this impact LIC?

LIC has strictly followed the practice of keeping distribution costs within accepted levels. We have, in fact, decreased or realigned the commission structure by spreading commissions over multiple years. We won't see much impact. If modifications are required, we will adapt quickly while balancing the interests of policyholders and agents. Insurance is not a pull product. The agent plays the role of a first-line underwriter. There is an additional effort involved in the sale of life insurance because the

agents need to understand the risk and ensure that it is properly disclosed to customers.

LIC's agency force has come down. Is that a conscious decision?

We do not want agents with us who are not very serious. We are looking at strengthening agents who will continue with LIC for a longer period through consistent performance.

Domestic institutional investors have been buyers while foreign investors have been selling. How is LIC, which has assets under management of around ₹60 lakh crore, approaching investments amid volatile markets?

Our approach is contrarian. We buy in dips and realise the profits when the market goes up. The market also gave us a good opportunity to lock in high rates of interest, so we have a good amount invested in fixed-income securities. The balancing is done continuously depending on market opportunities.

What is your outlook for the markets?

The market has been range-bound. It is too difficult to predict the direction given geopolitical uncertainties. The current situation keeps the yields high, which is good for locking in investments. At present, you have opportunities both in equity and debt.

AMID THE TEMPEST Review comes amid global uncertainty and a renewed push to attract foreign capital

investors, required under the 2016 treaty template, to first exhaust Indian legal remedies before pursuing global arbitration for dispute settlement, among other changes. Reducing this timeline remains a key demand of some foreign partners. Thakur said India stands for growth and stability in times of global turmoil. "Capital is not simply looking for high returns; it is also looking for stability, predictability and strategic resilience," she said. "That is where the importance of a stable macroeconomic and public finance framework comes in." Thakur said for the next phase of its development, the country needs to weave its macroeconomic policy, capital formation and industrial strategy into one coherent growth strategy.

She was speaking at an event organised by the National Council of Applied Economic Research in the national capital.

Thakur said the review of the bilateral investment treaty (BIT) model is a "work in progress" and consultations with industry are going on for this purpose. The review comes as the West Asia crisis sharpens the focus on drawing in more foreign capital. "We are looking at what the red flags are, and we have a negative list. We will set that aside, and see what is the maximum we can put out there," Thakur said.

ET had on June 5 reported that the government was examining whether to relax the five-year timeline for foreign in-



New Delhi: India should consider creating special employment regions, building cities around jobs, economist and 16th Finance Commission chairman Arvind Panagariya said on Friday.

He called for building cities akin to China's Shenzhen and Xiamen, which would be modern counterparts to existing Indian industrial cities such as Bokaro, Bhilai and Durgapur.

"These don't have to be empty pieces of land, and these could be areas where something already exists. Simply declare them as special employment regions and then build them up," he said at an event organised by the National Council of Applied Economic Re-

GREATER URBANISATION

Panagariya advocated reforms, focusing on greater land availability and ease of construction to accelerate urbanisation in India. Authorities should bring idle land to the market, turning it into a highly productive asset, he said. They should auction unused public and disputed land and reduce the minimum required lot size for institutions such as universities and medical colleges. He also favoured ending the requirement for prior approval to convert agricultural land for non-farm purposes. Building bylaws need to be liberalised, and a flexible zoning system should be promoted. Slums can be redeveloped into better living spaces, Panagariya said.

New Delhi: The Lok Sabha Friday passed the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026 that seeks to address delayed pa-

yments to MSMEs by introducing faster dispute resolution timelines, strengthening recovery mechanisms and improving liquidity for small businesses. MSMEs

contribute around 31% to the country's gross domestic product, 35% to manufacturing output and nearly 48% to merchandise exports.—**Our Bureau**

Decision may have followed Indian authorities questioning use of stock prices from exchanges here for derivative contracts traded on SGX

Mumbai: Singapore Stock Exchange (SGX) will stop offering trades of single stock futures linked to Indian equities from October.

What triggered this is not immediately clear but three senior industry persons told ET that the decision may have followed Indian authorities questioning the use of stock prices from exchanges here for derivative contracts traded on SGX.

In recent years this would be the second outcome of negotiations between India and Singapore in changing arrangements related to listed derivative trades with Indian equities as underlier.

Till 2023, SGX Nifty — a futures contract linked to India's Nifty 50 index — was traded on SGX, letting international investors take exposure to Indian stock movements without directly trading on Indian exchanges. Amid a surge in SGX Nifty trade volumes and India's efforts to bring back the off-

NEW ROUTE

The diagram illustrates a new route for India-Singapore derivatives market realignment. It consists of four main stages connected by dashed arrows:

- Move marks second India-Singapore derivatives market realignment:** Represented by a globe and a circular arrow with the Indian and Singaporean flags.
- Foreign investors may need to alter investment routes:** Represented by a blue arrow pointing towards a cluster of buildings labeled 'GIFT CITY'.
- Contracts may shift to GIFT City if trading migrates:** Represented by a document icon with a circular arrow, labeled 'GIFT CITY'.
- If shifted, contracts would mirror GIFT Nifty dollar settlement:** Represented by a 'GIFT Nifty' monitor showing a green upward-trending line and a stack of dollar bills.

shore trades that were being lost to Singapore, SGX Nifty was discontinued and replaced by GIFT Nifty.

This was achieved through a revenue-sharing framework agreed between SGX and NSE International Exchange in Gift City.

However, the end of single stock futures (tracking Indian stocks) on SGX may take a different course.

According to Rajesh Gandhi, partner Deloitte India, "Foreign investors who take exposure to Indian stock futures via SGX may have to realign how they invest depending on the framework which is ulti-

We are looking at what the red flags are, and we have a negative list. We will set that aside, and see what is the maximum we can put out there

Capital is not simply looking for high returns; it is also looking for stability, predictability and strategic resilience

Our Bureau



New Delhi: Oil minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Thursday dismissed concerns over fuel adulteration linked to India's ethanol-blending programme, saying nationwide testing found just four cases across 107,000 petrol pumps.

Oil marketing companies have been conducting "rigorous testing" for fuel adulteration across the country, he said.

"What did they find? They found our cases out of 107,000 petrol pumps with 6-7 crore (customers) coming every day. So obviously someone out there is trying to extract some things out of consumers," Puri said at a CII conference.

Concerns over the impact of ethanol-blended petrol on engine performance and fuel economy have intensified in recent months, with some automakers attributing vehicle damage to fuel adulteration. India supplies 20 petrol, containing 20% ethanol, as the standard grade at fuel stations nationwide.

CBIC Directs CGST Zones to Track Illegal Mining

New Delhi: The Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) has directed all central goods and services tax (CGST) zones to establish a formal information-sharing mechanism with state mining departments to track illegal mining and transportation of minerals and to curb tax evasion in the mining sector. The move is expected to strengthen GST enforcement in the mining sector, where tax authorities have long suspected revenue leakages due to illegal extraction and movement of minerals. —Our Bureau

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EXTRACT OF THE UNAUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30 JUNE, 2026

(₹ in lakhs except EPS)

Sl. No	Particulars	Standalone				Consolidated			
		Quarter ended 30.06.2026 Unaudited	Quarter ended 31.03.2026 Audited	Quarter ended 30.06.2025 Unaudited	Year ended 31.03.2026 Audited	Quarter ended 30.06.2026 Unaudited	Quarter ended 31.03.2026 Audited	Quarter ended 30.06.2025 Unaudited	Year ended 31.03.2026 Audited
1.	Total Income from Operations	111895.02	122849.20	142590.18	522799.54	146481.19	153021.17	158568.27	613259.81
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	1216.84	(767.93)	11697.57	22335.83	6865.44	2266.32	12120.80	25724.93
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	1216.84	(767.93)	11697.57	18497.57	6865.44	2266.32	12120.80	21886.67
4.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary Items)	592.48	(1068.96)	8604.09	13133.97	4836.67	1598.92	8907.83	16147.53
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after Tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after Tax)]	(552.63)	(858.67)	8294.71	13279.24	3528.13	3805.17	10650.51	22396.39
6.	Equity Share Capital	6181.84	6181.84	6181.84	6181.84	6181.84	6181.84	6181.84	6181.84
7.	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year				562159.87				586150.40
8.	Earnings Per Share (of Re. 1/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) –								
1.	Basic	0.10	(0.17)	1.39	2.12	0.78	0.26	1.44	2.61
2.	Diluted	0.10	(0.17)	1.39	2.12	0.78	0.26	1.44	2.61

Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of the quarterly and three months ended Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarterly and three months ended Financial Results of the Company are available on the Stock Exchange websites, i.e., on BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and on National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com and on the Company's website at www.electrosteel.com.

Date : 07 August, 2026
Place : Kolkata

For Electrosteel Castings Limited
Umang Kejriwal
Managing Director
DIN: 00065173



The banker to every Indian



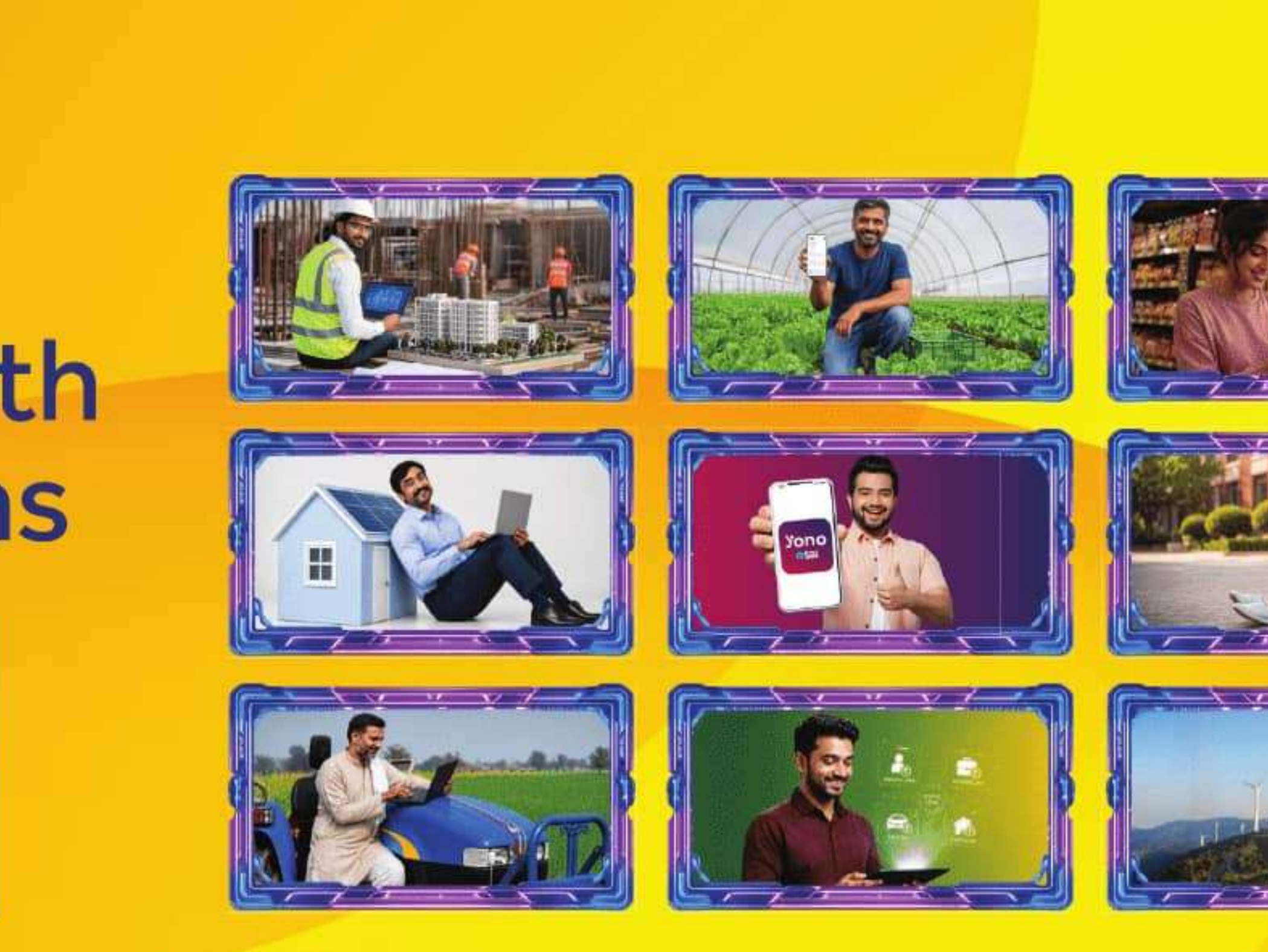
Power to every Indian

Empowering every Indian with digital solutions

DIGITAL FIRST

CUSTOMER FIRST

NATION ALWAYS



Scan to view detailed financial results



UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026					₹ In Crore			
Particulars	STANDALONE				CONSOLIDATED			
	Quarter ended 30.06.2026	Quarter ended 31.03.2026	Quarter ended 30.06.2025	Year ended 31.03.2026	Quarter ended 30.06.2026	Quarter ended 31.03.2026	Quarter ended 30.06.2025	Year ended 31.03.2026
	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)
Total Income from operations (including exceptional items)	1,43,819.15	1,40,411.77	1,35,341.56	5,56,240.67	1,80,061.86	1,81,079.02	1,66,991.82	7,12,643.53
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	28,482.41	24,832.02	25,785.27	1,00,883.56	32,883.80	26,075.51	29,229.12	1,11,001.41
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	28,482.41	24,832.02	25,785.27	1,05,476.78	32,883.80	26,075.51	29,229.12	1,14,027.98
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	21,121.22	19,683.75	19,160.44	80,032.01	24,113.00	19,642.87	21,201.47	83,298.78
Paid up Equity Share Capital	923.06	923.06	892.46	923.06	923.06	923.06	892.46	923.06
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year				5,09,114.00				5,60,786.78
Earnings Per Share (face value of ₹1/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) (₹) (Quarter numbers not annualised)								
Basic :	22.88	21.32	21.47	87.59	26.12	21.28	23.76	91.16
Diluted :	22.88	21.32	21.47	87.59	26.12	21.28	23.76	91.16
Total comprehensive income for the period (Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax) and Other Comprehensive income after tax)	Refer Note No.2							
Securities Premium Account	1,04,079.54	1,04,079.54	79,115.60	1,04,079.54	1,04,079.54	1,04,079.54	79,115.60	1,04,079.54
Net Worth	4,95,244.32	4,72,894.50	4,08,108.34	4,72,894.50				
Debt Equity Ratio	0.54	0.56	0.65	0.56				
Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	-	-	-	-				
Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-				
Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-				
Outstanding Debt	7,68,854.15	7,31,253.80	5,37,749.18	7,31,253.80				
Debt Service Coverage Ratio	-	-	-	-				
Interest Service Coverage Ratio	-	-	-	-				

Notes:

- 1) The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 & Regulation 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites: www.bseindia.com, www.nseindia.com and Bank's Website : sbi.bank.in
- 2) Information relating Total Comprehensive Income and Other Comprehensive Income is not furnished as Ind AS is not yet made applicable to the Banks.

Place : Mumbai
Date : 07.08.2026

By Order of the Board
Challa Sreenivasulu Setty
Chairman

STATE BANK OF INDIA, CORPORATE CENTRE, MADAME CAMA ROAD, MUMBAI - 400 021.

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VITALS

Praggnanandhaa Wins St. Louis Rapid and Blitz

St. Louis: Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa clinched his maiden Saint Louis Rapid & Blitz title in emphatic fashion, sealing the championship with a round to spare. The 20-year-old finished with 23.5 points, comfortably ahead of Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan, one of the contenders for the world championship cycle. Not losing any games on the final day of the last rapid and blitz. Praggnanandhaa jumped to second spot in the Grand Chess tour which almost guarantees a place in the grand finale scheduled later this year. The Indian will just have to keep up his form in the last tournament of the season which will be played under Classical system. **PTI**

Vinicius, Madrid Agree On Contract Extension to 2032

Madrid: Brazil star Vinicius Junior has agreed to a contract extension with Real Madrid to remain at the Spanish powerhouse through June 2032, the club has announced. The 26-year-old winger had entered the final year of his contract and reportedly had drawn interest from Premier League champions Arsenal. Financial terms of the extension were not disclosed. Vinicius wrote on Instagram: "Eight years at the Bernabeu are too few... 6 more years, and forever!" Los Blancos enter the 2026-27 season with a new coach - Jose Mourinho, for a second stint - and renewed expectations among fans. **AP**

Man City Reject Barca Bid for Rodri: Reports

Manchester City have reportedly rejected an opening bid of £38.5 million (\$52 million) from Barcelona for World Cup winner Rodri. The 30-year-old has just one season remaining on his deal at the Etihad Stadium and has been strongly linked with a return to his native Spain. City are understood to want about £68 million for Rodri, who was named player of the tournament at the recent World Cup in North America. Real Madrid had appeared likely to be Rodri's next club, but La Liga rivals Barcelona now seem to be in pole position. **AFP**

FIFA's Infantino Divide

Allies rally behind the president as critics call for his resignation

Aadi Nair

Football appeared to be headed for a prolonged standoff on Friday as allies of FIFA president Gianni Infantino rallied behind him while Norway demanded his resignation after several European associations withdrew their support. Confederations and national associations continued to choose sides a week after Infantino abandoned his proposal to raise some \$4.2 billion by selling off a stake in the commercial rights of the World Cup and other tournaments. Norwegian Football Federation president Lise Klaveness said Infantino no longer had the confidence of the football community.

"He does not have the institutional trust required to govern FIFA stably in the times we are in. There is no going back for Gianni Infantino," said Klaveness, a qualified lawyer. "The international football cooperation is very much in trouble, and we must have a reason to get together now, and we want to ask the FIFA president to resign now."

Meanwhile, European body UEFA, which has 55 members, stood firm in its threat to boycott all events organised by the global governing body.

However, Mexico's and Argentina's football associations were the latest to throw their weight behind the embattled world soccer chief, following the Confederation of African Football's (CAF) unanimous backing of Infantino's leadership on Thursday.

South America's CONMEBOL, meanwhile, expressed concerns over the "repeated unilateral actions taken without resorting to dialogue".

MEXICO BREAKS RANKS

The Mexican Football Federation (FMF), co-hosts of the recently concluded World Cup, broke ranks with its own regional confederation by supporting Infantino after CONCACAF had earlier called for a "comprehensive reckoning" with his presidency.

CONCACAF, which runs football in North and Central America as well as the Caribbean, has been among the key



INFANTINO'S BALANCE SHEET

Who has withdrawn support?

UEFA; England; Wales; Finland; Serbia; Sweden; Croatia; Albania; Greece

Who is opposing?

CONCACAF; AFC; Germany; Jordan; Denmark; Norway; Romania; Netherlands; Sierra Leone; Canada

Who is supporting?

CAF; Argentina; Mexico; Paraguay; Qatar; Sri Lanka; Kuwait; Lebanon; Indonesia; Philippines; Mongolia; Bhutan; Morocco; Egypt; Niger; Mauritania; DR Congo; Comoros; Malawi; Uganda; Gambia; Djibouti; South Africa

Who is yet to confirm a stance?

OFC; CONMEBOL

critics of FIFA alongside UEFA, which on Thursday said that its key conditions for a return to FIFA competitions had not been met.

European football's governing body said it remained committed to boycotting the World Cup until it received assurances that "such attempts to disfigure the game in this way will never be made again."

Asia's confederation (AFC) "stood in solidarity" with UEFA and CONCACAF,

although a few of its 47 members — like Indonesia, the Philippines and 2022 World Cup hosts Qatar — have come out in support of Infantino.

In CONMEBOL's statement on Thursday, it said it rejected any attempt to oust Infantino that did not involve a vote of all 211 members and Mexico's federation echoed those sentiments.

"The FMF supports President Infantino's leadership in continuing to promote the development of football through institutional strengthening."

ARGENTINA ACKNOWLEDGES ERRORS

In a letter to Infantino, Argentina's football association (AFA) backed FIFA's work over the past decade, praising its focus on global development and transparent governance.

While the AFA acknowledged that the proposal generated far more uncertainties than certainties and that errors had been made, it said that the way forward was to continue working under FIFA's leadership ahead of next year's Congress.

Paraguay's federation (APF) also published a letter of support addressed to Infantino, writing that it "reaffirms its commitment to continue working alongside FIFA."

On Thursday, players' union FIFPRO said Infantino's proposal was not just a governance failure but a "profound abuse of presidential power". **Reuters**

Where have India's Hockey Umpires Gone?

For the first time since 1998, there'll be no Indian in the men's hockey World Cup officiating panel

Mona Parthasarathi

New Delhi: India's absence from the officiating panel at the FIH Men's Hockey World Cup for the first time in nearly three decades has disappointed former international officials, who say a structured pathway and greater financial support are needed to develop the country's next generation of umpires.

The tournament, which begins on Aug. 15 in the Netherlands and Belgium, will be the first since the 1998 World Cup without an Indian umpire or technical official. European countries account for most of the appointments.

India has produced only four men's World Cup umpires in the modern era — Amarjit Singh Bawa in 1990, Tarlok Singh Bhullar in 1994, Satinder Sharma in 2002, 2006 and

2010, and R V Raghu Prasad in 2010, 2014, 2018 and 2023.

Raghu Prasad, the first Asian umpire to officiate in 200 international matches before retiring last year, said appointments for elite events are based on sustained performances in top-level competitions.

Satinder Sharma, who officiated in multiple Olympics and World Cups, described India's absence from the

India has produced only four men's World Cup umpires in the modern era



World Cup officiating panel as disappointing. "Our men's team did not qualify for the 2008 Beijing Olympics, but I was still India's representative there as an official. That shows how much importance is attached to consistent performances. At present, I feel we are lagging behind."

According to Hockey

India's list updated in May 2025, India's men's umpiring structure has four categories — Core Leading Panel, Leading Panel, High Potential and National Umpires — comprising more than 100 officials. The women's structure has more than 70.

Yet only six Indian men and four women are on the FIH umpiring panel, while India has four men's and two women's FIH technical officials.

Sharma said greater international exposure was essential if Indian umpires were to close the gap. "If domestic umpires don't officiate in major international tournaments, how will they gain experience? There is a huge difference between domestic and international umpiring," he said. **PTI**

INDIA TOUR OF SRI LANKA: WARM-UP GAME

Sri Lanka Youngsters Expose India Bowling Rust

India's bowlers came under pressure from Sri Lanka's young batters before spinners sparked a late recovery, with the hosts reaching 363 for 8 on the opening day of their three-day warm-up game on Friday.

The match does not have first-class status, with teams allowed to bat for 90 overs on the first two days and 45 overs each on the final day.

India's bowlers appeared rusty after five weeks without a red-ball game, while their spinners only began to exert control late in the day as the Nondescripts Cricket Club pitch offered some assistance to Kuldeep Yadav.

Opener Nishan Fernando led Sri Lanka's early charge with a brisk 66 from 65 balls, sharing a 110-run opening stand with Ravindu Rasantha, who made 71 from 143 balls.

Fernando, who recently played Tests on Sri Lanka's tour of the West Indies, handled Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh



Krishna with ease before being run out following a mix-up.

Gurnoor Brar was the pick of India's pace attack, taking one wicket for 49 runs in 12 overs.

Kuldeep, who conceded 29 runs in his first five overs, improved as the day progressed by varying his pace and flight. He finished with 2 for 76 from 18 overs, dismissing Ahan Wickramasinghe af-

ter a top edge off a sweep was taken by Brar at short fine leg before trapping Anjala Bandara leg before wicket.

Anav Suthar was India's most economical bowler, taking one for 30 from 11 overs. He deceived Rasantha in flight before later removing the set Dinusha. Ravindra Jadeja also took two wickets but conceded 64 runs in 15 overs and struggled to impose himself for much of his spell.

Skipper Shubman Gill, forced to sit out of the warm-up match after suffering an impact injury during training, head coach Gautam Gambhir and the India management will have plenty to assess after a testing opening day. **Agencies**

BRIEF SCORES SLC XI 363 for 8 (Rasantha 71, Nishan 66, Dinusha 52; Suthar 2/33, Jadeja 2/64, Kuldeep 2/76) vs **India**

LIVE on Sony Sports Network, 10am

Golf Courses to White House Lawns TRUMP TALKS TURF

The US president has mentioned grass at least 45 times in 18 months — turning lawn chatter into a recurring theme of his second term

AP

Washington: President Donald Trump will tell you: The grass is always greener on his side of the fence.

And tell you. And tell you. Trump has spoken repeatedly of his prowess with green lawns since returning to the White House — at some events even spending more time talking about it than the war in Iran, the economy or November's midterm elections.

It was on the president's mind just five weeks after his second inauguration, when he pointed out the Oval Office window during an interview with The Spectator: "You see the grass outside, right?" he asked before detailing his plans to pave over much of it. "Some people would like to leave it. But the problem is, you can't."

Trump has kept on the topic constantly ever since, saying as recently as Monday at a White House event with military spouses: "Grass is like humans. It has a life."

He's mentioned grass in at least 45 public events or interviews over the past 18 months — or at least once every 12 days. That doesn't include the numerous social media posts that he has also made on the topic.

Trump's gravitation toward grass speaks to his decades as a New York real estate developer and personal love of building things and overseeing construction projects. But it is also an indication of how much time he spends on the golf course and his extensive, second-term efforts to revamp the White House and greater Washington in his own image. The president has already far outpaced the 26 times he mentioned grass during the entirety of his first four-year term. "I know a lot about grass because I own a lot of golf courses," he said while announcing the recipients of the Kennedy Center Honors last August. "And, if you don't have good grass, you're not in business very long."

A week later, while visiting park police officers in Washington, the president declared, "I know more about grass than any human being. I think, anywhere in the world."

Matt Koch, the lawns research fellow for gardening giant Scotts Miracle-Gro Company, met recently with the president to discuss planting new grass on the White House's South Lawn. He proudly considers himself a "grass nerd" and came away convinced Trump is an honorary one.

"An amazing dialogue, talking grass for half an hour," Koch said of the Oval Office discussion. "Going back and forth about grass."

Trump has managed to bring up grass at events as varied as the signing of an executive order on TikTok and the 2025 White House celebration of Diwali. He mentioned it



"I'm very good at grass"

FILE PHOTO

while pardoning turkeys last Thanksgiving while addressing the World Economic Forum in Switzerland, and while signing a directive on quantum technology.

Last September, while hosting Republican lawmakers for dinner, he pledged of green spaces around Washington. "We're gonna re-grass them with the best guys in the country." That same month, during an event announcing the intended renaming of the Department of Defense, Trump assured attendees, "I'm very good at grass."

Trump most frequently mentions grass while promoting his Washington beautification efforts. In May, he spent 10 minutes of a Cabinet meeting detailing his efforts to fix fountains and give D.C.'s parks and monuments a face-lift — sometimes sounding more like a small-town mayor than the leader of the free world.

Ironically, the president brings up the topic while defending his decisions to remove grass for new construction — like when he covered the lawn near the White House's Rose Garden with a stone patio.

"Problem with the grass, you couldn't do anything with it," he said during a 2025 Oval Office tour for hosts of the "All-In" podcast.

The president also frequently recounts that hordes of women, including journalists, Cabinet members and administration officials, used to complain to him about their high heels getting stuck in the mud in the old, grassy Rose Garden.

"The women would be lifting up their shoes, saying, 'You've destroyed my shoes,'" he said during a luncheon last fall. When hosting the Los Angeles Dodgers in July, he relayed that women in heels "would go down like quicksand."

Silk Stalkings



Reshmi Dasgupta

Is it just algorithmic serendipity or is there really a renewed interest in and respect for Indian handlooms? National Handloom Day went by yesterday (in honour of the Swadeshi Movement that started on August 7, 1905) so a seasonal blip by marketers and influencers was expected. But ever since the event was instituted in 2015, I cannot recall younger people being that enthused to raid their mothers' and grandmothers' cupboards and wear a living legacy. This year they were.

Surprisingly, even the prime minister, using the social media term GRWM — Get Ready With Me — urged Indians to wear handloom on that day. His focus was, obviously, the younger generations, given their preference for visual cues. But by displaying handloom angavastrams, uttaris, gamosas or whatever that short length of textile is called in your part of India, the PM also, perhaps deliberately, highlighted that handloom does not only mean sarees and bedcovers.

That change in perception, admittedly, was already being wrought by "indie" labels that have been making handloom fabrics cool by fashioning them into trendy clothes for a few years now. Their predominantly young clientele had thereby realised that the magic word "sustainability" applies to handloom textiles in many ways even if they tend to bleed colour in washing machines. The young are figuring out that by wearing handloom they are also saving the planet.

Even handloom sarees are being taken beyond the traditional regional dyeing and weaving techniques, patterns and colour palettes. Designers are experimenting with using, say, extra weft jamdani weaves or mixing resist-dyed ikat motifs to create funky textures and patterns for handloom sarees that are quite stunning but also a far cry from grandma's beautiful traditional ones

Handloom's Fashion Reset

Because next fillip for India's handmade textiles must come from the young

ce" synthetic, machine-made fabrics. So, the amazing skill and hereditary muscle memory required to weave handloom textiles had disregarded as they were deemed just "craftspeople", several rungs lower than other "professionals". As they traditionally worked from home — a term that only gained respect during the pandemic — the sheer dimension of their work could never be brought into a single explanatory visual, unlike say, a giant car factory or even a textile mill. A single weaver family working on a piece of textile for days, weeks or months is not instantly attractive.

But there is a new understanding and respect now for what WFM entails and handloom has benefited from this epiphany. For decades the commendable drive to save handloom produce — and by extension, pure cotton and silk as its core raw material — from being obliterated by garments using

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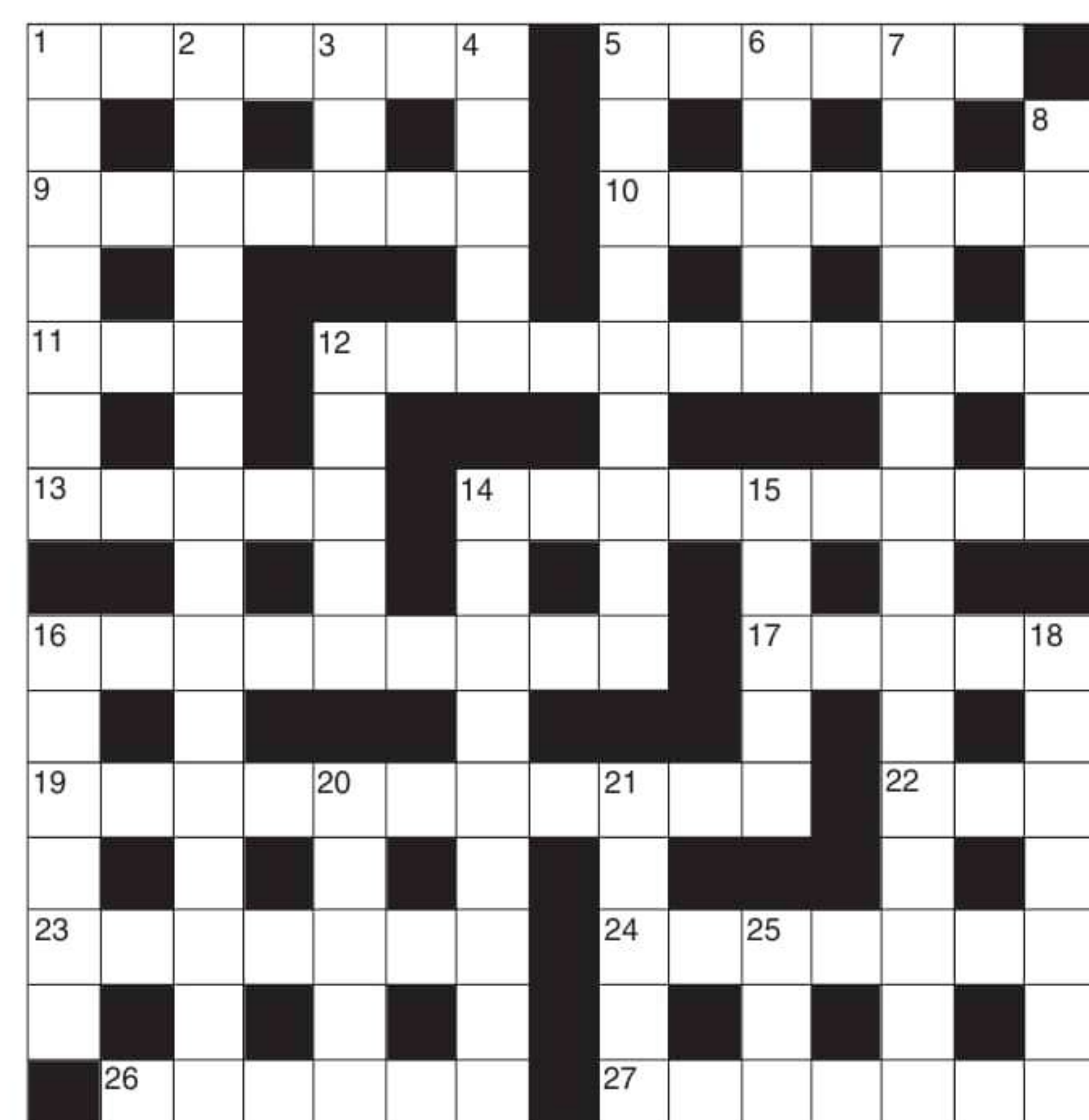
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cheaper, faster, blended-yarn machine-made textiles, remained confined to rarefied circles or even certain political orientations. The young, the middle and working classes were not really drawn into that charmed circle. Now, thanks to social media, the outreach is wider, and I daresay, more "mass".

It will certainly take some time for Indians to once again turn on a large scale to handloom from the more convenient "modern" textiles. But seeing young people commending them on social media sites now, portends that the fillip to the next phase of Indian handloom's future will be provided by them, and that too, not in the conventional form my generation is used to: sarees, yardage and bedcovers! Next step: when will corporate dressing allow handloom for men too?

Crossword

9672



ACROSS

- Enlist first of guys in vocation (7)
- Charles skirts odd points in some fissures (6)
- Spend time in corridor (7)
- Sadly aimless woman (7)
- Partly required anger (3)
- George, perhaps, is not partisan surprisingly (6,5)
- Outwardly describe piece and entry for what's owed (5)
- GP lapses, I suspect, in failures to meet deadlines (9)
- Urge dope to loosen attachment to

- a load (5,4)
- Take off carrying new underwater apparatus (5)
- Friend left in trouble losing pounds is unconcerned (11)
- Signal thing needed in snooker (3)
- Grains blended with a Spanish drink (7)
- One regularly logging? (7)
- A feature of the ocean in addition (2,4)
- Composed copy about figure showing strength (7)

SOLUTION TO No. 9671:

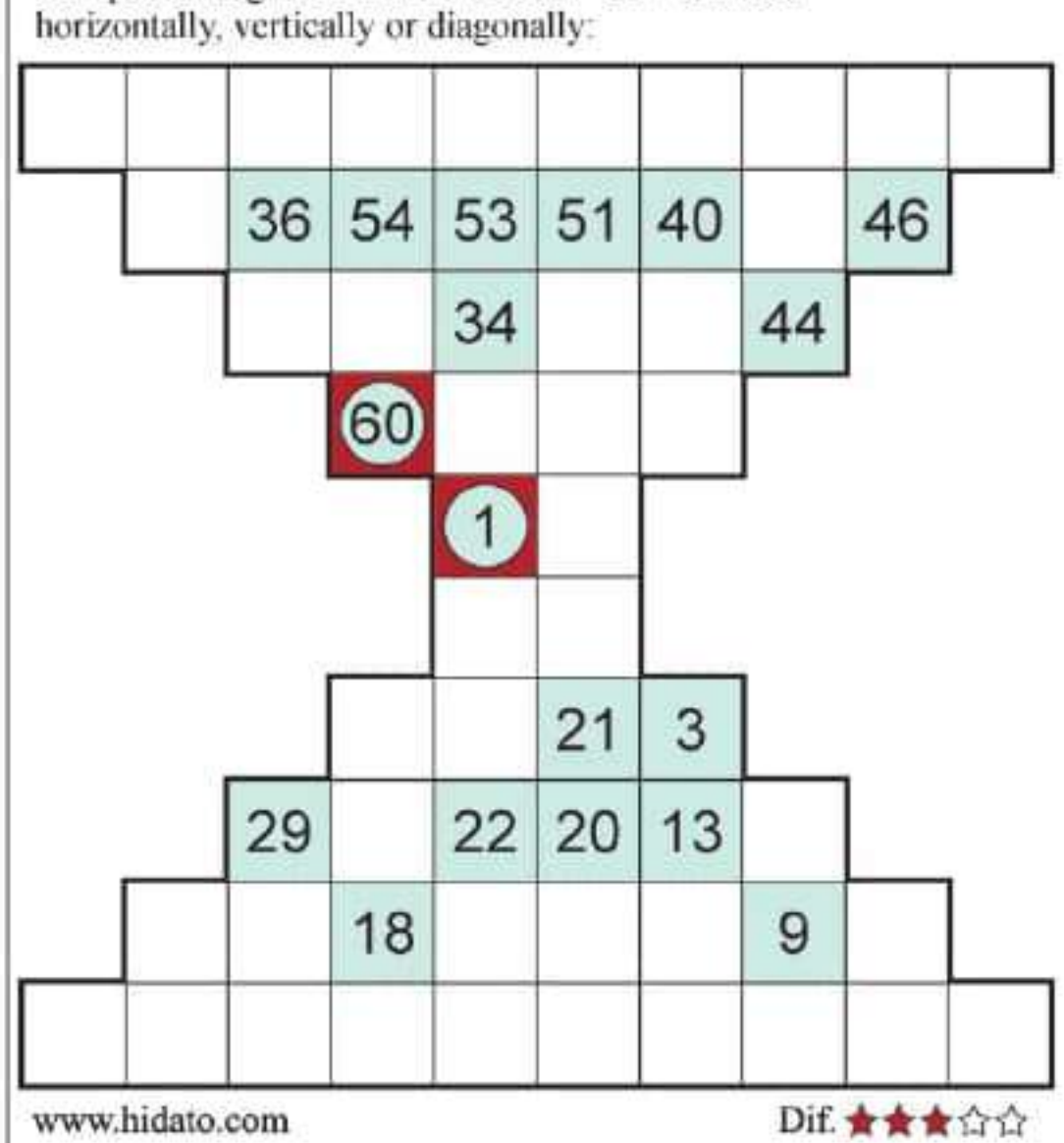
- ACROSS:** 1 Possessions. 9 Auroras. 10 Re-enact. 11 Echo. 12 Minivan. 13 Nearest. 14 Doc. 15 Libya. 17 Lotus. 18 Mimic. 20 Sumps. 22 Tab. 24 Cranium. 25 Airhead. 26 Eat. 27 Evident. 28 Trinket. 29 Small screen. **DOWN:** 1 Parent companies. 2 Shriveled. 3 Essen. 4 Strong-arm. 5 Overall. 6 Soaked to the skin. 7 Jammed. 8 Status. 16 Base metal. 18 Mocked. 19 Chimera. 21 Service. 23 Bids. 25 Attic.

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Complete the grid so that numbers 1-60 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally.



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Difficulty: ★★☆☆

Yesterday's puzzle solution.



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